provinces is one ostensible theme the book shares with Balzac (in the France of an earlier period). But the financial essence of "providence" is the key to this particular unmasking or deconstruction, and it is worth comparing it with Dickens's version, only a generation earlier.

For *Bleak House* shares a character with *Middlemarch*, and Fred Vincy's "great expectations" is a virtual replay, in a wholly different register, of the fate of poor Richard Carstone, that equally amiable young man famous for being able to spend the numerical sum he has economized in previous purchases without ever having had it in the first place.

But Dickens has concentrated this thematics of money in one site, the famous trial, thereby allowing him to denounce the psychological corruption of expectation as such ("there's a dreadful attraction in the place," says Miss Flyte; "there's a cruel attraction in the place. You *can't* leave it. And you *must* expect")[35] rather than in the money economy as such. But in *Middlemarch* there is no destiny which is not in one way or another touched by money. Dickens's "web" is thus occasional:

> There, too, [at Jo's sickbed] is Mr. Jarndyce many a time, and Allan Woodcourt almost always; both thinking, much, how strangely Fate has entangled this rough outcast in the web of different lives.[36]

But George Eliot's web is constitutive, as the multiplicity of her figures suggest—besides webs, threads, lines, scratches (on a burning glass), interweavings, etc. I leave it to the Mr. Casaubons of the English Departments to take the inventory of these recurrent figures (it being understood that no one with any interest in allegory and interpretation can afford utterly to despise Mr. Casaubon's labors, however ill-fated).

We need to dispel two persistent errors about this narrative "fabric" and the meaning to be assigned to it. The first, despite what we have said about money and the material basis of this alleged attention to "spirituality," is the religious connotation of a novel which begins with St. Teresa and ends with a memorable celebration of Dorothea's goodness:

[35] *Bleak House*, 566 (chapter 35).
[36] Ibid., 732 (chapter 47).

> for the growing good of the world is partly dependent on unhistoric acts; and that things are not so ill with you and me as they might have been, is half owing to the number who live faithfully a hidden life, and rest in unvisited tombs.[37]

Surely, despite the strength of all arguments against the concept of secularization which have been referred to above, such words, and the portrait of Dorothea that precedes and justifies them, testify to an unmistakable intent to secularize on George Eliot's part: the will to invent a figure of saintliness for a worldly and commercial society, and to reinvent a demonstration of the well-nigh material power of the kindness that radiates from Dorothea, gripping those around her with an almost physical force. It it clear enough that Eliot wishes to celebrate modernity (Lydgate's scientific passion, Garth's satisfaction in sheer productivity) without sacrificing the components of an older communal and religious culture virtually extinguished by it. But the ideological intent of the author never constitutes the "meaning" of the book, but rather, as Adorno pointed out, functions as a component of its raw materials. It will be possible to reinterpret Dorothea's centrality in another, non-ethical way, as we shall see in a moment.

The other fundamental misconception about the novels of this period (and of the later nineteenth century in general) is that, on the strength of their keen sensitivity to the movements of feeling and inner perception, they are somehow "introspective." But to range George Eliot (or Dostoyevsky, for that matter) among the novelists of introspection from Benjamin Constant's *Adolphe* to Proust is to obscure everything that is truly and formally original about her work. What we have here—as compared to Dickens, for example—is a significantly enhanced proximity to the relationships between individuals, a kind of intensified and well-nigh photographic enlargement of those barely perceptible adjustments to the Other, which Nathalie Sarraute, long after the fact, called "tropismes." What was wrongly identified as a self-consciousness or reflexivity of the individual self (now increasingly endowed with that private or personal reservoir entitled the Unconscious) can on closer inspection be seen to be a minute and microscopic negotiation with the shock and scandal of the Other, a reverberation of muffled reactions back and forth, as with the dance of insects confronting one another and attempting to gauge degrees of danger or attraction, if not neutrality. If a new theory

[37] *Middlemarch*, 838.

of modernity be wanted, then it might just as well be this one, the discovery, in philosophy and in artistic representation as well, of the existence of the Other as what Sartre called a fundamental alienation of my Being. Philosophy, except for Hegel's Master/Slave dialectic, altogether ignored the existence of other people as a philosophical problem that changed the very nature of philosophizing; as for literature, as long as the "other person" or character is imagined to be a kind of self-sufficient substance in itself, which occasionally comes into momentary or violent contact with other objects like it, but whose being is not fundamentally modified by the being of others, then it matters very little what kinds of psychological experiences are attributed to these independent tokens of narration. But when, as here, the other is seen to call me into question in my very being; when relationships take precedence over the beings in relationship, and a registering apparatus is developed which can detect such perpetual changes; when relationships are focused close-up in their intolerable proximity ("marriage is so unlike everything else," Dorothea reflects, "there is something even awful in the nearness it brings"),[38] then a new dimension, a new social continent has been discovered, which is the microcosm corresponding to the new macrocosms of collectivity on the level of cities and social classes.

After this, the intricate molecular patterns of a Henry James; or the violent spasms of cruelty and self-abasement of a Dostoyevky; and on into the multiple sub-atomic languages of what we are pleased to call modernism itself. We have already observed that the alternative of modernism and realism does not correspond to a classification system, but rather to a methodological focus, in such a way that it can scarcely be paradoxical for a "great realist" like George Eliot also, and from another angle, to be identified as a nascent modernist.

What needs to be taken into account for this to become more plausible is the ostentatiously omniscient and relatively archaic character of the style itself. But the latter imitates proverbs and traditional collective wisdom rather than anything redolent of Proustian self-expression, and thus disguises the innovative nature of its intersubjective raw material at the same time that it seeks to incorporate the latter into a quintessentially social knowledge, rather than to document the discoveries of some "new science" such as psychology or psychoanalysis.

[38] Ibid., 797 (chapter 81).

This "web" of interrelationships is now, on the one hand, to be grasped as an immense and mobile concatenation of events—encounters, looks, demands, self-defenses—rather than a static table of equivalences; and on the other hand—as synchronic nature also necessarily becomes visible—it is to be grasped in the form of interconnections that fan out well beyond the field of vision of the reader of any individual notation, and are yet modified by the most minute adjustments in the "lives" thereby brushing against each other.[39] What we must observe about Dorothea's saintliness is that it not only prolongs and perpetuates its effects across a multiplicity of neighboring connections, but that pain and suffering do so as well, and the various Dickensian wills—Mr. Casaubon's, Mr. Featherstone's, along with the deployment of money in his various projects by Bulstrode—are here transmuted into the vehicles of the transmission of bad vibrations across the same immense capillary system. But what has been lost in the shift from a diachronic providentiality—an attention to the salvation of the individual—to this synchronic vision is simply the ethical itself, or better still, any sense of evil as such. There is, in George Eliot, goodness, but its opposite is simply unhappiness; and we are forbidden to judge either Casaubon or Bulstrode as evil, even though their contemporaries may well do so.

The point is that, reinscribed in the web of interrelationships, what is painful or unhappy for one subjectivity in this immense network can, as it is transmitted over the links of a whole series, be transformed into something positive for others; just as the reverse can happen too.[40] But this possibility of the transformation of negative into positive, of suffering into happiness and back, clearly lifts these categories up into another supra-personal dimension and tends to efface older ethical or eudaimonic meanings. (It also forfeits the great game of the omniscient narrator, which is to know secrets which none of the characters involved will ever learn, ironically taking their unhappy

[39] Ibid., 795 (chapter 81). And see also David Ferris's exploration of the figure of the web in *The Romantic Evasion of Theory*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1994, 222–223.

[40] Mr. Skimpole's Panglossianism (in *Bleak House*) may be said to anticipate this transcendence of good and evil in a comic register: "'Enteprise and effort,' he would say to us (on his back), 'are delightful to me... Mercenary creatures ask, "What is the use of a man's going to the North Pole? What good does it do?" I can't say; but for anything I *can* say, he may go for the purpose—though he don't know it—of employing my thoughts as I lie here.'" (*Bleak House*, 294–5 [chapter 18]).

ignorance to their graves. Here, "essence must appear," as Hegel says, and the secrets, already appearing under the guise of their effects, must necessarily be revealed.)

But is not their misery—so vividly registered here in ways unequalled in the other novels of the time—a proof of George Eliot's supreme insight into psychology? In fact, in both Casaubon and Bulstrode, what we confront are masterful diagnoses of what Sartre will later on call *mauvaise foi*, the bad faith of self-deception and agonizing and impossible attempts at self-justification.[41] But these moments already contain otherness within them, in the form of judgement, in which the suffering subject interiorizes the gaze of the other and seeks to master and reorient it in his own favor. Indeed, as these tropismes become magnified by way of the novelistic or narrative medium, we glimpse a parallel magnification in the social itself, which is none other than the dimension of gossip, which enlarges the facts of interrelationship and transmits them onward to a circulation through the collectivity. It is the other face of my alienation by the other, and extends on into George Eliot's vision of history as "a huge whispering-gallery" in which we are ultimately privy to "the secret of usurpations and other scandals gossiped about long empires ago."[42]

Yet now providentiality returns, in an extraordinary and unexpected guise, at the moment when its actions and effectivities seemed all but undecideable. Casaubon and Bulstrode end unhappily; Lydgate's scientific ambitions are dashed and his marriage loses all its enchantment; yet contrary to all expectations, Dorothea's story ends well, and the renunciation (*Entsagung*) for which the German tradition, from Goethe to Fontane, had prepared us—let alone the terrible and emblematic solitude of spinster and widow from Balzac to Maupassant—is here dispelled by an utterly unexpected happy ending, for which we did not even dare to have "hope against hope" (and which, in hindsight, renders somewhat exaggerated the elegiac last lines about her which we have quoted above).

But the truly providential in *Middlemarch* lies elsewhere; and to appreciate it, we must note another significant feature of the providential-synchronic which we have hitherto omitted. We have learned, to be sure, that the synchronic and the diachronic are not to each other as space to time, nor even as the ahistorical to the historical, let

[41] See above, Part One, chapters VII and VIII.
[42] *Middlemarch*, 412 (chapter 41).

alone the non-narrative to the narrative; yet we would be justified in expecting time, history and narrativity to undergo some fundamental modifications as they pass under a synchronic regime. When, as here, we have to do with the synchronic as a simultaneity of destinies and a coexistence of a host of different narratives, what happens to temporality is this: the simultaneous time-lines become, as in Einsteinian relativity, difficult to reckon off against each other. It is simultaneity itself which becomes spatial, and in this new spatiality the various distinct temporalities can be adjusted against each other only with some difficulty, as in the voluminous historical concordances we might expect to find in Mr. Casaubon's papers.

Indeed the two series of events run side by side like Einstein's trains: who can tell what time it is outside, let alone inside? There are many train tracks, parallel and infinite, they keep overtaking each other in some ideal present; their own times overlap, cancel, outleap each other, overtake, fall behind. But every so often they overtake, not the other's, but their own past; they speed ahead of themselves and run through the line a second time.

Here, then, occasionally, something miraculous happens; and it is just such a miraculous happening that we are able to witness in the destiny of Fred Vincy, whose hopes of an inheritance and the estate called Stone Court are properly dashed at an early crisis in the novel, in which "realism" demands that the unrealistic hope and expectation be brought to its realistically anticipated unhappy end. This play with expectation constitutes a kind of novelistic "reality principle," which we find historically realized twice over in the classic Balzacian "hope against hope," and then in the gloomy fatalities of naturalism.

Here, on the contrary, it is the reality principle which must be joyously discredited; yet it is the test and the obligation of the form of providential realism to outwit sheer wish-fulfillment and daydream, to overtrump both fairy-tale endings and naturalist certainties with a new form of necessity. Fred Vincy will administer the estate after all (even if he does not technically inherit it), and this loop in time, in which the lost chance comes again against all odds, and the old hope is fulfilled after its definitive disappointment, is the concrete narrative embodiment of that religious iconography of resurrection with which we began, and the recuperation, by Eliot's voluminous realism, of the coming alive of the statue in *The Winter's Tale*: it is the salvational temporality of Ernst Bloch's privileged fable of the *Unverhoffites Wiedersehen* (a story by Hebel later rewritten and recapitulated by

Hoffmann), in which in extreme old age the widow of a dead miner is able to glimpse her long-lost husband once last time again as youthful as on the day he disappeared. What interests us here, however, is the way in which these stirring images find their own unexpected resurrection in the most seemingly unpropitious of forms, the nineteenth-century novel itself. It is an ecstatic ending which previous novels could only achieve by the glimpse of the ghosts of Heathcliff and Catherine wandering together over the moor.

6.

Now we must rapidly conclude, with only the briefest of glances at the descendency of this form in contemporary culture, and in particular in contemporary film. For both Quentin Tarantino's *Pulp Fiction* (1994) and Goran Paskaljević's *Cabaret Balkan* (1998, also known as *The Powder Keg*), if not indeed Milčo Mančevski's 1994 *Before the Rain*, seem to testify to a revival of effects structurally dependent on the apparent simultaneity of narrative time lines. Despite the bloodiness and violence of all these films, each conceals a salvational note underscored by the conversion of a professional killer, in the first-named of these works, to the old-time religion.

But it is to their prototype, in Robert Altman's *Short Cuts* (1993), that we must turn for some more fundamental structural insight into this new and old form, which seems to reflect an intensifying feeling for the interrelatedness of the social totality. In much of Altman's work, indeed (*Nashville*, 1975; *A Wedding*, 1978; *Pret-à-porter*, 1994; *Cookie's Fortune*, 1999; *Dr. T and the Women*, 2000), the multiplicity of plot lines and characters frequently leads to providential sparks and fires; and these are also, as we have seen with George Eliot, beyond good and evil, which is to say that the providential outcome can absorb either a happy or an unhappy ending indifferently, from what is a kind of Spinozan elevation.

But *Short Cuts* is the most revealing of these works, insofar as it reveals the very gesture of totalization itself. The film is based, indeed, on a compilation of stories by Raymond Carver, which for the most part offer unrelieved glimpses of failure and private misery. The one exception, "A Small, Good Thing," in which a fatal accident is unexpectedly transfigured by a symbolic wake, is then itself amplified, in its providential content, by Altman's combination of all these separate

stories into a web of episodes or multiple plots. Speaking of one of Balzac's shorter stories, Lukács once observed: "To treat this theme in a novel instead of a short story would require entirely different subject matter and an entirely different plot. In a novel the writer would have to expose and develop in breadth the entire process arising out of the social conditions of modern life and leading to these ... problems."[43] Altman's unification, however, achieves this miraculous transformation without any modification of the subject matter or plots of the stories, simply by a prodigious enlargement of their frame and context and a virtual creation, ex nihilo, of the totality they now come to express and represent. It is a passage from the private to the collective, from the static-ontological to the dynamic and the historically actual—the whole concatenation of episodes ominously overflown by the notorious med-fly fumigations of 1988 and shaken climactically by the major earthquake to come—which reinvents the providential narrative anew for late capitalism.[44]

[43] Georg Lukács, "Art and Objective Truth," in *Writer and Critic*, New York: Grosset and Dunlap, 1971, 54.

[44] See, for further elaboration of this thesis, my "Altman and the National-Popular" in *The Ancients and the Postmoderns* (Verso, forthcoming).

Chapter II

War and Representation

A vast entity, a planet, in a space of a hundred million dimensions; three-dimensional beings could not so much as imagine it. And yet each dimension was an autonomous consciousness. Try to look directly at that planet, it would disintegrate into tiny fragments, and nothing but consciousnesses would be left. A hundred million free consciousnesses, each aware of walls, the glowing stump of a cigar, familiar faces, and each constructing its destiny on its own responsibility. And yet each of those consciousnesses, by imperceptible contacts and insensible changes, realizes its existence as a cell in a gigantic and invisible coral [*polyp*]. War: everyone is free, and yet the die is cast. It is there, it is everywhere, it is the totality of all my thoughts, of all Hitler's words, of all Gomez's acts; but no one is there to add it up. It exists solely for God. But God does not exist. And yet war exists.

–Sartre, *The Reprieve*

Stalingrad is like a painting that cannot be observed from close up, but from which one must step back in order to do it full justice.

–Joseph Goebbels

I.

War offers the paradigm of the nominalistic dilemma: the abstraction from totality or the here-and-now of sensory immediacy and confusion. For Tolstoy, as for almost everybody else, the representational consequence was most memorably drawn by Stendhal in *The Charterhouse of Parma*: its naive young hero setting forth to join the Emperor's army and blundering into the middle of the battle of Waterloo without even recognizing his hero as the latter gallops off what he does not even understand to be the battlefield. The protagonist thereby gives expression, avant la letter, to what the Formalists called "*ostranenie*" or "estrangement" (defamiliarization), in which a preexisting stereotype is dismantled and brought before us in all its

nameless freshness and horror. Whether this is to be grasped as an essentially modernist operation, or on the contrary is something all the realisms are by definition called upon to do, is a question we will for the moment leave open.

Still, it suggests that there exists some preexisting stereotype of war for such passages to defamiliarize, and that there must then also be representations of war that are content to reconfirm the stereotype. Indeed, one often has the feeling that all war novels (and war films) are pretty much the same and have few enough surprises for us, even though their situations may vary. Indeed, we can enumerate some seven or eight of those situations which more or less exhaust the genre. If so, and despite experience which confirms this opinion, this would be in itself an astonishing fact, given the radical changes in warfare the historians document since the hand-to-hand combat in the plains before Troy (Hegel's prototype of that human and unalienated form, the epic, as opposed to the modern "prose of the world," denatured by money, commerce and industry): there is then, marked by technological advances (gunpowder, machine guns and tanks, aircraft, unmanned cybernetic weaponry), a whole periodization of structural changes in warfare and its accompanying strategies which needs to be combined with the narrative typologies we are about to enumerate and to examine in more detail. Add to this complication a periodization of properly aesthetic modes and transformations (allegory, realism, modernism, postmodernism), and we confront a combination scheme of no little complexity which may strike us ultimately as serving less to explain these representations than simply to classify them. But perhaps such possibilities, which account for the organization of the notes that follow into a sampling of exhibits rather than a unified and systematic theory, may also be reduced and simplified by the rather different consideration which cuts across all of them—namely the suspicion that war is ultimately unrepresentable—and by the attention to the various forms that the impossible attempt to represent it may have taken.

As for the narrative variants, which seem to me to hold for film as much as for the novel, I enumerate eight of them: 1) the existential experience of war; 2) the collective experience of war; 3) leaders, officers, and the institution of the army itself; 4) technology; 5) the enemy landscape; 6) atrocities; 7) attack on the homeland; 8) foreign occupation. The final category does not include the related subject-matter of spies and espionage (now largely settled into a generic category of

its own); nor does it exhaust the phenomenon of guerrilla warfare, from the current US occupation of Iraq and Afghanistan all the way back to the Vendée and indeed to the earliest institutionalization of armies as such; for guerrilla warfare—the result of uneven development and of the incursion of an "advanced" mode of production into an "underdeveloped" one—can also offer the very prototype of war itself and not its savage exception. Yet these very exclusions suggest a different way of cutting across these plot-types, for the typical events of foreign occupation (and of espionage for that matter) take us back to institutions and to the state as actor and agency; while the horror of guerilla warfare (whether urban or rural) would seem rather to lie in the unidentifiability of its actors, who emerge from their surroundings without warning and just as unexpectedly disappear again.

What may prove most helpful here, then, is Kenneth Burke's "dramatistic pentad," which differentiates between act, agent, agency, purpose and scene as so many distinct perspectives through which the narrative material can be focused.[1] To use a different, more structural terminology, we may say that each of these categories constitutes a different kind of dominant and thereby produces a somewhat different projection of the material, it being understood that there is no correct or "true," photographically accurate rendering of such multidimensional realities. Still, narrative semiotics, by reidentifying Burke's first three categories with each other—an act always somehow implying an agent and the agent in turn implying an agency—suggests a different ordering of these perspectives, in which purpose somehow withdraws (as a feature of interpretation rather than of representation), while scene begins to emerge as a whole new element in its own right, in which the anthropomorphic gets eclipsed and some new and as yet unrecognizable narrative reality comes into view. For the act and its accompanying actantial categories always presuppose a name, and thereby a preexisting concept of the event thus identified (as already with the word "war" itself), while action and agency themselves seem to be determined and simplified in advance by this or that institionalized and organized agent. Scene, however, remains at an unmodified level of narrative complexity, only becoming concrete in the course of the representation. Spatiality is only one possible

[1] See Kenneth Burke, *A Grammar of Motives*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1953.

dimension of scene, to which anthropomorphic elements are subordinated in unaccustomed and estranged ways.

Technology, meanwhile, as alienated and reified human labor and energy, is always a slippery category, moving back and forth between allegory and external (or proto-natural) doom, yet sometimes also celebrated as the triumph of human inventiveness and the expression of human action (or its prosthetic extension). It wanders back and forth across all our tale-types, sometimes organizing their very periodization (as we have suggested above), sometimes generating a uniquely nightmarish experience in its own right, as in the sheer terror and panic aroused by the appearance of the first tanks at the Battle of the Somme in World War I; or that of the V-2 rockets in its sequel. Yet technology is truly the apotheosis of a properly modernist teleology, describing, as Adorno put it, a direct line from the sling-shot to the megaton bomb. Each innovation is somehow also the same in its embodiment of radical difference: as witness Ermanno Olmi's wonderful film *Il mestiere delle armi* (2001) on the development of artillery in the sixteenth century.

The first category, of the existential experience of war—which has its classical literary realization in Stephen Crane's *Red Badge of Courage* (1895)—most often expresses the fear of death and that somewhat different thing, the death anxiety: as such, although this category is surely the quintessential form the representation of war will take in most people's minds, its content (personal danger, decisions and hesitations, contingency, apprenticeship) can be transferred to other generic frameworks. War then becomes that laboratory in which, as with the bullring for Hemingway, such experiences are most unfailingly aroused and observed. Yet it tends towards the category of the *Bildungsroman* to the degree to which it is generally a question of a very young and inexperienced soldier, whom the event does not leave untouched.

With the collective focus, however, everything changes; yet here also we find ourselves in the presence of a content fully interchangeable with several other familiar and well-defined genres which call the generic specificity of the war film back into question. For the collective war story turns on the interaction of various character types apparently gathered at random. The experience is the national one, of universal conscription as the first occasion in which men from different social classes are thrown together, at least until the public high school dramas of more recent memory. In the Europe

of emergent nationalism, the experience was called upon to level the old regional cultures (Sicily, Brittany) and to standardize language and the claims of authority and the state—discipline as well as obedience, and acknowledgement of national unity. The American films, taking class difference for granted and only gradually absorbing racial difference, found their originality psychologically, in the typology of personalities thrown together in the group (or war machine). The intelligent upper class figure, the sociopath, the weakling, the bully, the fixer, the jokester, the trickster, the Don Juan, the ethnic type (generally southern European, but a black man, a Chicano, an Indian, comes later on), the religious fundamentalist, the "nice guy," the nerd. The list is endless but the combinations—that is to say, the fundamental dramatic conflicts and clashes—are probably statistically limited and certainly generically predictable.

The crucial thing about this collective system is that it is itself the abstraction of something else. We may focus the action in terms of male bonding or the psychology of hierarchical institutions, with the problem of authority figures (either incompetent or psychotic, etc.) added in later on. The first versions of the form emerge in what we may call a pre-feminist world; and certainly the absence of women is a significant structural part of the form—later on, women will be admitted as yet another variation on the male character types—but it is above all the absence of the family and of peacetime, indeed of wage labor itself, that is the crucial feature here. This is why a juxtaposition with the heist or caper film is so interesting: for in this last we find the same abstract structure, the same variety of character types and their clashes, the same as it were sealed social world in which now even the legitimacy of the institution of the army and the "declaration" of war has been stripped away, giving us all this in a different kind of defamiliarization, where the overall aim of the collective action is not even "war aims," defeating the enemy, defending freedom, or some such socially plausible motive, but rather simply money itself—the ultimate abstraction, the ultimate "axiomatic" emptied of all concrete content. Yet the absence of wage labor or commodified labor is here retained; and as with many other kinds of crime films, there is a Utopian overtone in which the characters are allowed to live in a disalienated world, and in which activity is akin to play. (I have elsewhere tried to show that these Utopias can be invested with very different valences: thus the mafia film quintessentially appeals to

nostalgia for the family by way of unconscious collective envy for the southern European clan system).[2]

Thus, what both war films (of the collective buddy type) and caper films abstract from and yet dramatize in their own specific generic ways is the division of labor itself: each of these character types stands for a certain type of competence, something brought out much more strongly in the caper films, where each is precisely selected on the basis of that competence. The overall small or micro-group is the Deleuzian nomadic war machine, literally or figuratively, that is to say, the image of the collective without the state and beyond reified institutions. Still, such "groups-in-fusion" as Jean-Paul Sartre calls them in the *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, are also, as they themselves harden and ossify, forerunners of the institutional as such. Indeed, when the peacetime army comes into its own mode of representation (or indeed the police force itself, in current procedurals), it is rather bureaucracy whose epic is here sung before us (without being named as such, except in socialist realism), and the collective structure of the nomads is reappropriated for the celebration of the state. Both are indeed themselves afterimages of the social, and we make a more productive use of Deleuze when we grasp his dualism as an alternating possibility and realize that libidinal investment in the nomads can be no less reprehensible (but also no more so) than libidinal investment in the state itself.

As for the third category, of leaders and institutions, it initiates a shift of gravity towards the exterior of the experience of war, whether individual or collective, for the officers are ordinarily as much a part of the external environment of the soldier as the enemy itself, and are indeed equally often objectified into what gets identified as the bureaucracy or the state. Initially, however, such characters furnished the staple of the older chronicle history, with its great men and world-historical figures—what Lukács assigns to the potentialities of the stage, as in Schiller's *Wallenstein* or Strindberg's *Gustavus Adolfus*, or even Shakespeare's war-ridden history plays (and the short-hand German imitations that come out of them, like Goethe's *Goetz von Berlichingen* or even Kleist and Büchner). This is, on one traditional yet rather narrow acceptation of the term, the place of politics as such; and it cannot be doubted that the various populist representations of

[2] See "Reification and Utopia in Mass Culture," in *Signatures of the Visible*, NY: Routledge, 1990.

the simple soldier and the common man in uniform are dialectically later than these less and less glorious figures striding about the stage and vocalizing their decisions, with or without a note of human, all-too-human pathos.

Yet Tolstoy's notorious loathing for Napoleon is in that sense merely the other face of his hero-worshipping portrayal of the uniquely Russian bluffness and acumen of Kutuzov, a historical figure Tolstoy himself had not many years before this characterized as "sensual, cunning and unfaithful"—just as he had called such patriotism "a fairy tale which aroused national feeling"[3] in earlier times. Perhaps the classic defamiliarization of the "great general" comes closer to Tolstoy's representation of "world-historical" decision-making and his inveterate resistance to it (a stance to which we owe the concluding "theory of history" in *War and Peace*):

> But at that moment an adjutant galloped up with a message from the commander of the regiment in the hollow and news that immense masses of the French were coming down upon them and that his regiment was in disorder and was retreating upon the Kiev grenadiers. Prince Bagration bowed his head in sign of assent and approval. He rode off at a walk to the right and sent an adjutant to the dragoons with orders to attack the French. But this adjutant returned half an hour later with the news that the commander of the dragoons had already retreated beyond the dip in the ground, as a heavy fire had been opened on him and he was losing men uselessly, and so had hastened to throw some sharpshooters into the wood.
>
> Prince Andrew listened attentively to Bagration's colloquies with the commanding officers and the orders he gave them and, to his surprise, found that no orders were really given, but that Prince Bagration tried to make it appear that everything done by necessity, by accident, or by the will of subordinate commanders was done, if not by his direct command, at least in accord with his intentions. Prince Andrew noticed, however, that though what happened was due to chance and was independent of the commander's will, owing to the tact Bagration showed, his presence was very valuable. Officers who approached him with disturbed countenances became calm; soldiers and officers greeted him gaily, grew more cheerful in his presence, and were evidently anxious to display their courage before him.[4]

This pretense of freedom in the face of necessity, however, pales in comparison with the criminality of the officers' decisions in World War I, as so memorably exemplified in Kubrick's *Paths of Glory*

[3] Boris Eikhenbaum, *Tolstoi in the Sixties*, trans. Duffield White, Ann Arbor: Ardis, 1982, 149 and 144.

[4] Leo Tolstoy, *War and Peace*, New York: Norton, 1966, 163.

(1968); and it is to be remarked at this point that many mass cultural genres—the police procedural, the spy novel—end up turning less on the pursuit of the enemy or the official other, than they do on their own institutional framework itself, with its ineffective and ill-informed command system and the internal subversion of moles and double or triple agents.

Perhaps the abstract theoretical debates on strategy and tactics are relevant here in a new and more formal way. The debate on the influence of Clausewitz, for example—whose notion of war as a duel is as anthropomorphic as Hegel or Homer; his notion of the decisive final battle a thoroughly narrative one (which has wrongly been criticized for omitting the very different dynamic of guerrilla warfare); and even the famous maxim of war as the continuation of politics by other means—suggests a way of translating warfare and its specialized personnel back into more familiar peacetime and civilian realities amenable to the techniques of the more conventional realist novel.

Yet behind all such discussions lies a narratological problem, a challenge to anthropomorphic representation and the mimesis of human actions and characters: the question of whether such possibilities are not altogether obsolete in the age of nuclear weapons, drones and suicide bombers. These are the debates waged back and forth across history by the generals and commanders, the dictators (in both ancient and modern senses) and the war leaders. They reenter the narrative representations of war in the form of unwarranted hero-worship and blind allegiance, or the sense of betrayal, or the contempt of foot soldiers for stupid officers, or the cowardice of the general staff. These are all what semiotics terms "actantial" questions, issues about action and human agency; and even our fourth category of technology seems to move uneasily in and out of the whole area of personification and anthropomorphism.

When it comes to the next set of categories, however, my sense is that the focus of the war narrative subtly changes, and that in Kenneth Burke's dramatistic pentad, we have begun to move from the first four Burkean categories to the fifth, which he called scene and to which he attributed a different and perhaps more diffuse kind of rhetorical and representational power.

2.

For even atrocities might seem to us today to belong rather to the malignant properties of evil or cursed landscapes than to the savagery of an individual actor; and it is as though with this and our other later plot-types we pass from a world of acts and characters to that of space itself—scene, landscape, geography, the folds of the earth that determine military campaigns in the sense of contingency or the main chance, a heterogeneous element which is that of *Stimmung* or affect fully as much as of some mere stage or "context" for human gestures. The bombs falling out of the sky are part of it, along with the lunar landscape of trench warfare; the silence of deserted villages is a narrative player in such tales, along with the menace of empty windows and the complicity of nature in ambush or pursuit, in concealment as well—camouflage being the way that humans acknowledge the primacy of Scene, just as maps are another.

Meanwhile this category then abolishes or suspends the distinction between the enemy's landscape and our own, the latter no less fraught with peril than some unknown, hostile terrain. For here the great hand-to-hand duels of the armies—Napoleon versus Kutuzov, Wallenstein versus Gustavus Adolfus—give way to the imagery of penetration—the first glimpse of a sea of tanks at the battle of Kursk, the smell of sweating armies miles away in World War I, the screaming of the dive bombers, the first exposed steps in an abandoned hamlet—the space of modern warfare is vulnerable by definition, and no longer belongs to anyone.

But that was also the case in the Thirty Years' War, whose most extraordinary literary document begins in full incursion and horror, as the mercenaries (of whatever affiliation) loot the villages and torture the peasants for food and gold:

> Da fing man erst an, die Stein von den Pistolen and hingegen an deren Staff der Bauern Daumen aufzuschrauben, and die armen Schelmen so zu foltem, als wenn man halt Hexen brennen wollen, massen sie sich einen von den bereits in Backoven Steckten, and mit Feuer hinter ihm her waren, ohngesehen er noch nichts bekannt hatte; einem anderen machten sie ein Seil um den Kopf and rettelten es mit einem Bengel zusammen, das ihm das Blut zu Mund, Nas and Ohren heraus sprang.
>
> Then they used thumbscrews, which they cleverly made out of their pistols, to torture the peasants, as if they wanted to burn witches. Though he had confessed to nothing as yet, they put one of the captured hayseeds in the bake-oven and lighted a fire in it. They put a rope around someone else's head and tightened it like a tourniquet until blood came out of his mouth, nose, and ears. In short, every soldier had his favorite method of making life miserable for peasants, and every peasant had his own misery.[5]

The period has indeed virtually become defined by such atrocities, which I am tempted to count into the Scene and space itself as one of its properties during this long war in which most of central Europe is consumed, at all scales from macroscopic to microscopic: armies pursuing each other from one end of Europe to another, enemy battalions unwittingly colliding in marshes during the night, bands of marauders burning villages, a deserter ransacking an empty house:

> "Noses and ears cut off to make hatbands"... "the robbers and murderers took a piece of wood and stuck it down the poor wretches' throats, stirred it and poured in water, adding sand or even human feces..." "they tied our honest burgher Hans Betke to a wooden pole and roasted him at the fire from seven in the morning until four in the afternoon, so that he gave up the spirit amidst much shrieking and pains.'"[6]

With such nightmares, indeed, one has the sense that the two categories—of internal invasion and intervention and of war carried to foreign, unfamiliar territory—somehow coincide and dialectically reinforce each other. This is not so much the pseudo-synthesis of a "civil war" (an oxymoron if there ever was one) as rather an utter transmogrification of the familiar into the alien, the "*heimlich*" into the "*unheimlich*," in which the home village—the very limit of the world itself and the boundary of the real and the everyday—is transformed into a place of unimaginable horror, while the neighbors of the home country—the eternal peasants, the stock characters of village life—become sly faces of evil and of menace, ambushing the soldier who strays from his company and lynching the few they can safely overpower, concealing the food and hiding in the woods like savages (anachronistically to redeploy that Fenimore Cooper imagery

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[5] Hans Jakob Christoffel von Grimmelshausen, *Der abenteuerliche Simplicissimus*, Munich: Artemis & Winkler, 1956, 17. English translation: *The Adventures of Simplicius Simplicissimus*, trans. and abridged by G. Schulz-Behrend, Columbia, SC: Camden House, 1993, 7.

[6] Christopher Clark, *Iron Kingdom: The Rise and Downfall of Prussia, 1600–1947*, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2006, 32–4.

that Balzac so relished). But this is something that happens, not so much to people or individuals—characters as such—as to the landscape itself, which fades in and out of nightmare, its mingled dialects now intelligible, now the gibberish of aliens.

Some such Gestalt-like metamorphosis from familiar to unfamiliar, from the anthropomorphic to the micro- or macroscopic play of the material elements themselves, can be observed in what the Thirty Years' War itself imposes on our attempts to conceptualize it as a whole. On the one hand, the great strategic trajectory of the armies of a Wallenstein or a Gustavus Adolphus, of ferocious condottiere like Mansfield or the Bavarian general Tilly, of the Spanish armies of intervention in search of the enemy and of some final and decisive bone-jarring clash; on the other, a well-nigh optical enlargement, an eyelash-brushing approach in which the seemingly intelligible units of the official armies disintegrate into minute bands of individual marauders spreading across an everywhere identical landscape of fields and woods, huts and paths, and offering the same scenes of carnage and flight over and over again, beyond history, beyond narrative.

Nor is this only caused by the complexity of this block of historical time, with its innumerable agents and actors (who constantly change position and swap their functions with one another), a multiplicity only momentarily simplified by the conventional stereotype of religious war and the climactic struggle between the Counter-Reformation and Protestantism as such. For the Counter-Reformation is already divided and multiplied by the triple centers of the papacy, Madrid and the Habsburg Emperor Ferdinand II (more Catholic and fanatical than the pope, or than his own Spanish relatives); while what is loosely called Protestantism—already locked in internecine warfare between its two, Lutheran and Calvinist, branches both of them anathematized by innumerable millenarian sects—is itself susceptible to infinite fission and the propagation of innumerable subsidiary local and foreign conflicts.

To assign the guilt of striking the first blow is a philosophical quandary of the first magnitude; while even the most warlike of the participants—Wallenstein for example—can also be read as embodying a humane will to peace, to the ending of the indefinite proliferation of the war and an establishment of central European unity on a new basis. (Even Schiller's Hamlet-like version of the great generalissimo's assassination leaves us with multiple interpretations of his motives:

Does he want to found a dynasty and make himself Emperor? Does he want to unite Germany in some prefiguration of nineteenth-century nationalism? Is he indeed, against all appearances, a moderate and a peacemaker? Or even a Protestant sympathizer? Etc., etc.)

In fact, although Ferdinand would like to repeal many of the confessional compromises of the preceding century, it is the Protestant side which provides the provocative and incendiary pretext: the Protestant elites of Prague, dissatisfied by Habsburg sovereignty, persuade Friedrich, the Elector of the Palatinate, a son-in-law of James I of England, to assume the throne of Bohemia, normally a prerogative of the Emperor's dynastic lineage. But the Elector only wins the mock title of Winter King, owing to his brief tenure, cut short by the decisive battle of White Mountain (1620), and leaving the unhappy Friedrich to wander from ally to ally in search of a renewal of fortune, in a hapless quest which turns him into the very allegory of weakness and indecision. Here is a modern version of this uninspiring and vacillating figure, perking up somewhat at the prospect of meeting his mercenary generals, themselves revived by the intermittent and sluggish streams of cash flowing reluctantly into the Hague, "refreshed by the sums like flowers in the dew," as they ride out to greet their sometime employer:

> Die beiden, von den Summen erquickt wie Blumen vom Tau, ritten ihrem Kurfürsten auf der Landstraße zum Haag entgegen; sein Herz schlug kräftiger, als er die starken Pferde und die gepanzerten unbändigen Männer antraben sah. Erzählten ihm vom König Christian und den prächtigen Niedersachsen, wie gern der Kaiser auch Magdeburg schlucken wolle und von dem neuesten Ankerseil des löblichen Hauses Habsburg, dem gewissen Wallenstein. Und sie freuten sich zu dritt über den gewissen. Der schlaffe Friedrich fühlte sich wieder erwachen, hineingerissen in das alte Leben zwischen den davontosenden schweren Kürissern.[7]

> His heart beat strongly in his breast as he saw powerful hooves drive these armored and undisciplined men towards him. They told of the Danish king, Christian, and of Lower Saxony, magnificent in its prosperity; told also how the Emperor lusted to swallow up Magdeburg, and gave news of the latest effort of the distinguished house of Habsburg to acquire a reliable mooring, namely a certain Wallenstein, the three making merry over this unknown name. And the slack Friedrich felt himself awakening to life again, swept back into the old excitement by the proximity of these two stormily galloping, heavily ironclad warriors.

[7] Alfred Döblin, *Wallenstein*, Munich: DTV, 1983, 248, trans. mine.

The stereotypical vacillation (shared by the Emperor) does not equip this personage to be a protagonist, any more than the grim but indistinct determination of the true instigator of this war, the Bavarian Elector Maximilian, entitles him to be the villain of the piece.[8] But we must also pause here a moment to register the existence of that extraordinary literary document, the novel entitled *Wallenstein*, an untranslated and visionary nightmare dreamed out and written up by the young surgeon Alfred Döblin in the evenings of the bloody trench warfare of World War I and published in 1920, nine years before the *Berlin Alexanderplatz* that made him world-famous. No background in Döblin, no preparation, no perspective, it comes before us as a perpetual present which is at every moment, on every page, in every sentence, filled space, not a pause or backward or forward glimpse—the armies in movement even when they are at rest in their temporary quarters—the army's pauses are themselves movement, they hint at some sly signal of Wallenstein, rebuking the Kaiser by not following his directions, feinting the enemy, pretending to obey the commands to stop (says one of the imperial counselors, "es ist mir nicht klar, gegen wen der Herzog Krieg führt").[9] Yet filled at every moment with names, with all the characters of history, some known, some only mentioned in passing; and with place names as well, not even the map is enough to accommodate them all. It is a pulsing interminable uninterrupted flow, true textuality (not mere form without content) in which everything is in perpetual change back and forth across Central Europe yet driving forward temporally so that time itself, the passing instants, become invisible, only the events are generated and they never stop, the writer never stops (he thereby disappears also), and the sources are so thoroughly used up that nothing is any more allusion, Schiller has long since vanished, there can be no longer any competition with this unending flow of text but only the affect that pulses through it and changes color from pallor to flush, purple to yellowish-sallow, all the tonalities of the affective spectrum stream through the interminable moments, none of them truly fulfilled or effectuating any lasting pause or destiny.

Not the least interest of this novel is indeed the recurrence in the form of an allegorical habit profoundly consanguineous with the baroque content of its setting in the Counter-Reformation. Thus here

[8] Golo Mann, *Wallenstein*, Frankfurt: Fischer, 1971, 299–300.
[9] Ibid., 254.

it is money itself that ultimately revives the unhappy Winter King: the lifeblood of the money that runs through the immense continental expanse of the conflict, feeding it locally and reorganizing its forces into impermanent groups, from the foraging deserters and guerillas all the way up to the official and unofficial warlords and officials of the official royal and imperial adversaries. The great and bloody rhizome of the war then becomes a representation of money, riches, wealth, taxes levied, the very sustenance of potatoes impounded from villages in flames and peasants dead or in flight. Everything here—from the penniless imperial court, who count on Wallenstein to raise forces for them at the same time that they try to give him orders, all the way down to the brutal *soldateska* who live off the countryside—has to do with money, and with an immense coral polyp that refuses to starve or die away but keeps itself in life for unforeseeable years by the very strength with which it draws money out of its hiding places, like magnets drawing, or blood from a stone, soaking it up interminably, reproducing itself, using its population of generals, peasants, priests, burghers, kings, lepers and landless, heiresses, as so many divining rods, so many instruments for draining the last drops of wealth or riches from the devastated land. Wealth then becomes the very conduit of energy itself, whether blood, sexuality and libido, activity, irritability, sensation, impulse, drive, propulsion, it is what makes the sentences pound forward like horses' hooves as well as the human individuals themselves to their otherwise incomprehensible yet irrepressible heat-seeking clashes. The libidinal apparatus of the war—of this extraordinary, unique war—thus ensures the most fully realized representation of finance and its networks and capillary extremities, it makes wealth in its "early modern" sense appear before us as a phenomenon in its own right, in the strong Heideggerian sense of the *phainesthai*, the appearance of Being, in ways frontal narratives of trading companies and usurers were unlikely to convey, or the abstractions of religious moralizing or economic philosophy.

Yet all this eventuates in blood and landscapes of dead bodies, the world of Callot anachronistically revived within that of World War I, which reproduces it only for reasons of historical underdevelopment, because its generals failed to grasp the proper use of machine guns or of tanks. Still, we may wonder what forms the representation of agents and agency takes under the regime of the Scene, in this interminable narrative of events and sequence of grotesque or nightmarish figures, more human in their caricaturality than any of the genuine human

beings of realism or of our acquaintance. No causes, to be sure, and yet immense allegorical figures, like the famous frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan*, or better still, Arcimboldo's vegetable portraits, in which the sovereign is called upon to incarnate his own multiplicity and his own multitudinous subjects. But here the "world-historical figure" allegorizes not subjects or a people, not even the collectivity of the men under his command, but rather his own victims and the corpses he has in effect become. Here is Tilly, one of the more fearsome of these legendary imperial warlords, as he entertains an audience with the equally fearsome Wallenstein himself:

Der Brabanter, steif, gespenstig, mit einer weissen Schürze, zwei Pistolen und einem Dolch im Gurt, kurze weisse Haare; an den Haarspitzen schwankten ihm wie Ähren die Tausende erschlagenen Menschen. Sein bleiches spitzes Gesicht, buschige Brauen, starrer borstiger Schnurrbart, überrieselt von den verstümmelten Regimentern eines Menschenalters; sie hielten sich rutschend an den Knöpfen seines grünen Wamses, an seinem Gurt. Seine knotigen Finger bezeichneten ein jeder die Vernichtung von Städten; mit jedem Gelenk war ein Dutzend ausgerotteter Dörfer bezeichnet. Über seine Schultern schoben sich her, zappelten die Körper der gemetzelten Türken, der Franzosen, der Pfälze, und doch sollte er damit erscheinen vor Gericht einmal, samt ihren Pferden und Hunden, die uber dem andern, eine ungeheur Last, so daß sein Kopf samt dem Hütlein darunter verschwand. Die aufgerissenen roten and borkigen Hälse, Bäuche mit weißen regsamen Farben, geädert, triefend über die geschlitzten zurückdrängenden Arme und die einknickenden Beine. Darmschlingen am langen Gekröse, in die er sich verwickelte, wampend und schwabbelnd über die sich stemmenden leder verwahrten Knie, eine riesenlange weiche wurmartige rieselnde Schleppe, an der er ruckte riß keuchte, wenn er ging. Ein Mammut belastete er den Boden; aber eisig hielt er sich, hörte nicht das Gebrüll der Menschen, das markerschütternde der Schweine, schrillen Pfeifen der Pferde, die sich alle an ihn hielten, ihr Leben aus ihm saugen wollten, aus den feinsten Röhrchen seiner Haare; herumlangende Pferdehälse, nüsternzitternd, scheckig, schwarz; zerknallte Hunde, die nach seinem Mund, seiner Nase schnupperten, gierig seinen Atem schlürften. Er mußte längst ausgeleert sein, sie sogen an einem dürren Holz, er klapperte drin und sie brachten ihn nicht zum Sinken.

Hinter ihm vierzehn Regimenter zu Fuß und sechs zu Pferd.

Der Friedländer ihm gegenüber ein gelber Drache aus dem böhmischen blasenwerfenden Morast aufgestiegen, bis an die Hüften mit schwarzem Schlamm bedeckt, sich zurückbiegend auf den kleinen knolligen Hinterpfoten, den Schweif geringelt auf den Boden gepreßt, mit dem prallen, breiten Rumpf in der Luft sich wiegend, die langen Kinnladen aufgesperrt und wonnig schlangenwütig den heißen Atem stoßweise entlassend, mit Schnauben und Grunzen, das zum Erzittern brachte.

Hinter ihm vierundzwanzigtausend Männer.[10]

The Brabanter [Tilly], stiff and ghostly, with a white scarf and two pistols and a dagger in his belt, and short white hair; at the hairs' tips like ears of corn there waved the corpses of a thousand men cut down. His pale sharp features, bushy brows, stiff brush-like moustache rippled with the mutilated regiments of a whole generation; they clung in slippage to the buttons of his jerkin, to his belt. His gnarled fingers each one testified to the annihilation of whole cities; with every knuckle a dozen exterminated villages. Over his shoulders there crowded forward, writhing, the bodies of slaughtered Turks, Frenchmen, Palatiners, and yet someday he would meet his judgement with them on himself along with their horses and dogs, hanging every which way in front of each other and one on top of the other, a burden so immense his very head and little hat vanished beneath it. Necks ripped open and scabby, stomachs with white and livid colors, veined and dripping on the slit and restrained arms and the spastic legs. Guts in loops of intestines in which he was wrapped, sloshing and flabby over the braced knees encased in leather, an interminable limp wormlike rippling train which as he dragged it creaked with every step. He weighed the earth down like a mammoth; but bore himself icily, deaf to the screams of the men and those, bone-shattering, of the swine, the shrill cries and piping of the horses, all of them holding to him, seeking to suck their life out of him, out of the most minute hairs on his head; horses' necks straining, their nostrils trembling, piebald, black; dogs shot to pieces and yet snuffling at his mouth and nose, greedily sucking up his breath. He should have long since been drained; they were sucking dry wood; he clicked and clattered around inside and yet could not be brought down. Behind him fourteen regiments of infantry and six of cavalry.

In front of him Friedland [Wallenstein], a yellow dragon emerging from the bubbling bogs of Bohemia, plastered with black slime to the hips, drawn back onto his knobby hind legs, sulphur pressed into the earth ringing him, waving his broad elastic rump the air behind him with his big jaws wide open, blissfully and with the fury of a serpent exhaling hot breath in intermittent blasts, with a panting and grunting that struck fear.

Behind him, twenty-four thousand men.

These portraits, which we may characterize as rehearsing the modes of allegory and symbol respectively, are drawn into an uninterrupted stream of filled time and space, of a visual writing only occasionally punctuated by dramatic scenes, by a "showing" which mainly takes second place to the "telling" of the visionary nightmare which feeds on the interminable war as on indefinitely renewable fodder.

Wallenstein's biographer gives us a more articulated picture of the perpetuum mobile of this infernal machine, which seems unable to

[10] Ibid., 243–4

run down and stop (and indeed Wallenstein's function, for good and ill alike, is to have been able to supply the gradually less and less enthusiastic Kaiser with ever renewed reserves of troops):

> After not much more than a year [after White Mountain], people began to fear that the rapid exhaustion both sides felt was premature. A definitive victory would have to be a universal one and could never have existed. Partial victories, however, each of which related to the whole in a different way, called new enemies into the field, who then gave new energies to the old adversaries, humiliated and pillaged. Bohemia, although isolated in its captivity, remained a part of Europe and Germany even more so, owing to its size. This is not merely an individual opposition, a struggle between two power centers or the aggression of a single one of them. It is a tidal succession of wills in conflict, some of which claim to be able to form them into a single unified will and campaign against another one, and yet never do completely subsume the wills of their individual allies. A fencing court. Individual pairs joust. Suddenly they form two fronts which begin to move in opposition to each other. Yet as they do so, the ballet of betrayal sets in within each. One party withdraws into a corner, exchanges meaningful looks with its former adversary, manoevers between the two fronts, seeking to mediate. Another tries to entice this or that participant out of both fronts and to form a third. All this laden with illusion, mistakes, deception. No one knows enough about the other, and some don't even know their own minds.[11]

This fencing ballet of the war as a whole, as in an aerial shot, stands in sharp contrast to the horrors on the ground, as recorded by Grimmelshausen and others—a kind of no man's land in which all spaces are identical and all the atrocities as well, a kind of nightmarish repetition moving from Bohemia to the Baltic and back, as it were a triumph of space and identity over time and its differentiations, a virtually non-narrative flow for which the only appropriate registering apparatus or point of view would seem to be the eyes of an idiot or of a child, as in Ambrose Bierce's terrifying story "Chickamauga."

3.

And this is indeed how *Der abenteuerliche Simplicissimus* begins—the supreme literary monument produced by this war by one of its participants, its six books published in 1668 and 1669, some hundred and fifty years after *Don Quijote* and *Lazarillo de Tormes* and another fifty before *Robinson Crusoe* (1719). Yet it is clearly incorrect to characterize

[11] Golo Mann, op. cit., 287–8, trans. mine.

Simplicissimus as a picaresque novel or even as a *Bildungsroman* (the hero is certainly a naif, who seems to maintain his innocence even during those episodes in which he has technically become a trickster figure). Not only is this enormous text episodic in the extreme, it is also rhizomatic, a kind of hyper-text throwing off all kinds of ancillary episodes, at least one of which, *Courasche* (1670), has known a prodigious afterlife in Brecht's theatrical version.

But we will argue that *Simplicissimus* is more than episodic, it is an extraordinary machine for generic production, for the narrative space tirelessly generates one new genre after the other, from the "war novel" and the "lives of saints" all the way to the final Utopia and desert island narrative. How to account for this unparalleled literary autopoesis, this non-teleological proliferation of generic exercises, which goes well beyond what has been identified under the term "generic discontinuities"? Is it possible that it is precisely out of that undifferentiated space of local yet universal conflict, whose fever chart runs from the plundering of villages to the sacking of whole cities and back, that in the absence of ready-made narrative micro-forms the various genres are themselves summoned into existence?

At any rate, we begin virtually in the state of nature, in which the youthful protagonist scarcely has language, and in particular either does not know his own name or has none, being ordered around the field by his brutal father (whose very status is registered in dialect—"*knan*"—equally bereft of a family name). He flees into the woods during the mercenaries' sacking of the village from which we have quoted above, and there meets a pious hermit who instructs him both in religion and, even more remarkably, in the classical languages and their rhetorical traditions. (The causes of this saintly hermit's withdrawal from the world, a premonition of Simplicius' own eventual destiny—it is indeed the hermit who thus baptizes him—will be related in a later discovery, which recapitulates the different genre of unhappy love). Upon the death of the hermit, the boy returns to the world of social beings, first becoming page to the governor. He is then abducted by Croatian mercenaries and incorporated into the imperial troops, where, after a number of humiliations, he reemerges generically as the trickster figure we have mentioned above, a *Jäger* supremely gifted in warfare and plunder or theft of all kinds, after which he marries, and then in a more magical episode discovers treasure.

Yet these potential destinies are all abruptly broken off, whether out of impatience or boredom, or owing to the serial production of

the various books, if not the fermentation of new genres at work in Grimmelshausen's feverish imagination. There follows a salacious episode in Paris, a spell as a travelling salesman, and a fall into the truly bad company of a real thief who tries to teach him the way of the real world ("du bis noch Simplicius, der den Machiavellum noch nit studiert hat"[12]). The boy then undergoes a religious conversion, founds a new landed estate and family, undertakes a Vernian journey to the center of the earth, and finally sets forth on travels that ultimately lead to his shipwreck and a hermit-like existence on a desert island, where autobiographical notes are found by a Dutch sea captain, who brings them back to Europe and to publication.

Finally, it is not so much the narrative quality of the various episodes that strikes the reader, as rather the restlessness of the character's exploration of his various possible destinies, and that of the author's experimentation with the various narrative genres they carry within themselves. We are here, in the German principalities of the empire, still very far even from the sophistication of the Spanish monarchy, in which the first realisms flourished so many generations earlier, and in which the urban worldliness of commercial life and colonial and military power generate the picaresque, along with an extraordinary theatrical culture. Germany is here still profoundly pre-novelistic, and indeed the first crystallizations of form in Grimmelshausen's seemingly interminable text take the form of immense allegorical dream frescoes—most strikingly that of the class divisions and struggles of the feudal world, with its prelates and nobles at the top of the allegorical tree and the nameless peasantry at its very base,[13] along with the dream transformation into an animal, reminiscent of *The Golden Ass* of Apuleius. But it would be equally incorrect to read such allegorical episodes as the mere self-indulgence of an autodidact reveling in his classical education. For in this great laboratory of forms, Baroque allegory is closely affiliated with Utopia as such, which one may perhaps thereby in hindsight identify (in More) as itself an allegorical form.

The devastated landscape, indeed, calls out for the relief of Utopian transfiguration: such is the first crossing of the border into Switzerland:

> The landscape struck me compared with other German lands, as strange as Brazil or China. I saw people trading and strolling about in peace, barns full of cattle, courtyards full of chickens, geese and ducks, the streets were used by travelers in safety, taverns full of people making merry, no fear of the enemy, no worry about plundering and sacking, no anxiety about losing land or life and limb, everyone lived safely under his grape arbor or fig tree, and in comparison with other German lands in pleasure and content, so that I took this country for an earthly paradise, although it seemed primitive enough.[14]

[12] *Der abenteuerliche Simplicissimus*, 353.

[13] Ibid., 45.

Later on, among the hallucinations of the desert island, this earthly paradise will be transformed into a vision of primeval bliss—"so we lived like the first men in the golden age, where a bountiful heaven lets all the fruits of the earth flourish without work"[15]—until the devil in the form of a woman shatters the vision and sends the text itself, in the generic reversion, back into the anchoritic withdrawal of its own beginnings.

I want to draw the conclusion that war, perceived at this existential proximity of Scene, is virtually non-narrative, and that this raw material seeks to appropriate its missing protagonist from any number of narrative paradigms, ranging from the conventions of generic war novels or films enumerated at the outset, to the multiplicity of generic experiments of Grimmelshausen's peculiar text.

4.

It is a hypothesis we may now test on the aerial warfare of World War II, about which it will be recalled that the most famous representation of its most famous (European) atrocity—*Slaughterhouse-Five*—sets the firebombing of Dresden offstage, behind the sealed door of the protagonist's eponymous cellar. About this kind of warfare, W. G. Sebald, who grew up in a part of Germany untouched by the air war and exiled himself to England at an early age, has oddly maintained that the Germans have repressed its experience, and indeed that of the defeat in general.[16] He excepts from this accusation one of the most remarkable writers (and filmmakers) of modern Germany, Alexander Kluge, whose portrayal of the battle of Stalingrad (*Schlachtbeschreibung*) already presents many of the features to be noted in the account of the bombing of his native city of Halberstadt on April 8, 1945.

[14] Ibid., 391, trans. mine

[15] Ibid., 582, trans. mine

[16] See W. G. Sebald, *On the Natural History of Destruction*, New York: Random House, 2003. And see also Sven Lindqvist, *A History of Bombing*, New York: New Press, 2003.

It was indeed Kluge from whom we selected the remark of Goebbels that figures as a motto to the present essay; and it is in precisely this sense that Stalingrad seems to disintegrate into a host of unrelated colors and brush-strokes as we gradually approach our eyes and faces to the canvas itself.[17] It would be facile to characterize this text as a deconstruction, either of the traditional narrative account of the battle, or of the battle itself. Yet in some literal sense the word is apt, provided that we take it backwards, as the account of the various elements and raw materials which went into the building of the phenomenon hereby unbuilt: indeed, the subtitle of this work is very precisely "the organizational construction of a catastrophe." Kluge here redistributes the building blocks of the defeat in what may be called non-existential segments; which is to say non-narrative units set side by side in a kind of collage. We here find extracts from an army manual on winter warfare side by side with historical accounts, pictures of the landscape, interviews with survivors, medical descriptions of the most characteristic wounds and mutilations, a chronology, the propaganda rhetoric of pastors and preachers on the subject, the language habits of the officers and staged press clippings and conferences, dispatches from the front, the whole interlarded with anecdotes and other stray observations and testimonies, among which Hitler's own vacillations and tactical inattention are duly registered in passing—in what could, I suppose, be called a "non-linear" narrative if one still likes that kind of terminology. It should be understood that Kluge's interest lies in the enumeration of destinies and the deployment of anecdotes, and not in any sustained or "novelistic" storytelling or longer sustained narrative breath; it may be said that he practices a unique type of didactic abstraction, in which a given outcome is x-rayed for the components it incorporates of life-promoting or lethal energies respectively.

"The Bombing of Halberstadt" (*Chronik* II, 27–82) is another such collage, in which individual experiences, in the form of anecdotes, are set side by side not so much for their structures as the acts of traditional characters (Burke's agents), so much as names and destinies, the latter being reduced in many cases to peculiar facts and accidents, of the type of Ripley's Believe It or Not. The juxtaposition of these anecdotes with quotations from academic studies of the history of

[17] Alexander Kluge, *Chronik der Gefühle*, 2 vols., Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 2004, Volume I, 509–791. All page numbers in text refer to this edition, and translations are mine.

bombing and of the RAF techniques, scholarly conferences on the relationship between aerial strategy and ethics ("moral bombing" is for example specified as a matter, not of morals, but of morale), or indeed interviews with the allied pilots who participated in this particular raid—all these materials, which we take to be nonfictional (although they may not be, the interviews in particular bearing the distinctive marks of Kluge's own provocative interview methods) raise the question of the fictionality/non-fictionality of the personal stories of the survivors as well. Halberstadt is to be sure Kluge's hometown, and he is perfectly capable of having assembled a file of testimonies and eyewitness documentation, and of using the names of real people. On the other hand, these stories with their rich detail afford the pleasures of fictional narrative and fictional reading.

Is this text (written in the 1970s) a nonfiction novel? I believe that we must think our way back into a situation in which this question makes no sense and in which—as with the storytelling that precedes the emergence of the so-called Western novel—the distinction between fiction and nonfiction (or history) does not yet obtain, any more than that (so closely related to it) between figurative and literal language. This is not to say that Kluge marks a regression to pre-capitalist storytelling, but rather on the contrary that postmodernity as such has now rendered those distinctions obsolete in the other direction: now, it is not so much a question of all narrative being fictional as it is of a reading process which is always literal, even when we are reading what is technically a fiction.

At any rate, it can be argued that the opening section of "The Bombing of Halberstadt" is less a matter of assembling the personal experiences of the survivors, the moments of the first bombs—in what amount to six successive waves of bombers—than it is of a use of named individuals to map the small city itself (64,000 inhabitants) as they try to make their way across streets increasingly blocked by fires and rubble. (Indeed, we will learn shortly that such attacks follow a specific and intentional pattern: first, strikes calculated to identify targets by columns of smoke identifiable from the aircraft; then the systematic blocking off of streets so the fleeing population is trapped; then an initial destruction of roofs and top storeys, with a calculated time lapse in order to allow a later wave of bombers to drop new explosives through the holes and set fire to the buildings as a whole: procedures carefully designed in order to produce the so-called fire storm characteristic of such raids.) A certain amount of curious

detail is amassed here, such as the effort of the civilians to get rid of flammable materials such as the stocks of paper in the newspaper offices, or hosing down groups to survive the heat. Mainly, however, these opening chapters document the regression of the civilians into their private obsessions and neuroses and their decidedly meaningful and intentional, yet aberrant, activities, as with the random scattering of an ant-hill. Thus, in the opening section, which, so characteristically for this writer-filmmaker, deals with the local movie theater, the Capitol, and its manager, Frau Schrader (the owners are on vacation in the country), this particular character is at first worried about the next matinees at three and six o'clock (the first bombs begin to fall at 11:20 a.m.), and only later about the bodies of the initial spectators. Her emotional low-point is reached, however, when she finds nothing to do and "feels herself 'useless'": not danger and death, but the blockage of activity is the phenomenon that interests Kluge here.

The agitated movements of these named and presumably real-life characters, however, serve to map out the streets they attempt to negotiate, the routes in and out of town, and the position of key buildings—the institute for deaf-and-dumb children, for example, or the church tower on which civilian volunteers are stationed, in order to observe and report the attacks, which of course exceed anything they had expected and at the same time destroy any number of telephone lines and other channels of communication. Both these situations will be given a turn of the anecdotal screw in the second part, in which the postwar interviewer inquires into the possibility that a white flag of surrender had been shown on the tower ("surrender to whom?" the American pilot asks; "how do you surrender to a squadron of bombers?"); while a colonel attempts to get information by telephone about the state of things around his sisters' home outside of town (from Magdeburg, owing to the destruction of the lines, he has to "make connections via Kroppenstedt, Gröningen, Emersleben, Schwanebeck, and then back through Genthin, Oschersleben and further south via Quedlinburg"; he never gets through, although the operators realize that this is not official but rather private business). From the two parts we may retain (and compare) the initial attempt of Hen Grämert to rescue his twelve thousand tin soldiers, which represent Napoleon's winter campaign in Russia, along with the episode of the "unknown photographer" (characteristically, the surviving photographs are here reproduced, along with much visual material in Part II); and the episode in Part II in which a teenager succeeds in

mastering his piano lesson but not in persuading his piano teacher to reschedule his lesson for the next day, upon which, escaping the burning city, he takes refuge in a village where he practices non-stop so energetically that the owners have to tell him to give it a rest.

Part II, indeed, lets us into the formal secret of this work (I will not say its message or its meaning exactly) with its differentiation of a strategy from below and a strategy from above (the latter, to be sure, outlines the bombing techniques and conveys what it would be improper, as we shall see, to call the "point of view" of the American pilots). Thus Gerda Baethe has learned that the pressure from the bomb blasts will damage the lungs; she tries to make her small children hold their breath during the explosions. Meanwhile, Karl Wilhelm von Schroers, a convalescent veteran in charge of the prisoner-of-war camps in Halberstadt, eagerly visits key points in and out of the city, giving and taking orders, but above all satisfying his keen scientific curiosity. This characteristic, like Gerda's "strategies," is not to be understood in any subjective way, even though the two are vivid personalities succinctly conveyed in a page or two. In keeping with the neutrality of this text and with the generic focus of the anecdote as a form, these are external or objective traits, of the type one registers for other people, as when we note that someone (a proper name) is "quick to anger," or that some other proper name is "indecisive."

But Schroers is more significant than that, insofar as his "scientific curiosity" constitutes something like an "aspiration to totality" which his position on the ground can scarcely satisfy. He is indeed a "collector of strong sense impressions" (66).

> His capacity to feel increasingly curiosity rather than anxiety is not based on any lack of imagination. To be sure, with his physical eyes he only sees this particular tavern, a partial view of Wherstedter Bridge (and nothing of the torn up rails) and perhaps a few houses, but he can imagine the whole city. What he doesn't know [we are still in the night before the bombardment] is that this will be the last conscious glimpse of the cityscape intact. (68)

Like Frau Schrader, he has his later moments of depression (owing to the absences of goals and intentions to be fulfilled, activities to be carried out), but at length recovers his original energy and "curiosity."

Another cameo appearance is made by the head of the fire brigade, who deplores the ignorance of the city officials and their haste to extinguish fires that will be controllable only at the later stage of their chemical life and development, and who takes a reasoned decision to

allow the city archives and its museum contents to go up in flames: "I was virtually the last person in this city to see its valuable memorabilia, to say farewell, to estimate the value of the collection" (78).

Here the micro-perspective, the view from beneath, dwindles to its vanishing point. Yet it should not be imagined that the view from above, that of the pilots and crew, is any more comprehensive or reliable. Indeed, as has already been hinted, there is in fact no view from above insofar as the pilots are not expected to see but rather to determine their movements by map and by mathematical calculation, by radar rather than by "sight" (an expression that here in any case signifies strategy rather than the personal organs of the participants [54n12]). All of the studies of aerial warfare and its techniques foreground the depersonalization of the individuals involved and their assimilation into the larger machinery, first of their own aircraft, and then of the squadron as a whole. "Here there do not fly individual airplanes as in the Battle of Britain, but rather a whole conceptual system, an intellectual construction in metal" (51, to quote from one of the discussants at the aerial warfare symposium also represented here).

Abstraction versus sense-datum: these are the two poles of a dialectic of war, incomprehensible in their mutual isolation and which dictate dilemmas of representation only navigable by formal innovation, as we have seen, and not by any stable narrative convention. It is not to be imagined, however, that we can return to some earlier state of wholeness, in which, as in Homer, the individual hand-to-hand combat would at one and the same time somehow epitomize the totality.

On the other hand, the contradiction can be exacerbated even further, as it continues to be in contemporary warfare. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri have evoked a kind of dialectic of the body in the most recent American wars, in which the solitary body of the suicide bomber, on the one hand, finds itself opposed, on the other, to the smart bombs and pilotless drones of an aerial warfare visible only on monitors at thousands of miles of distance—a contradiction itself reproduced in the distance between the conventional duel of armies ("mission accomplished") and the house-to-house urban resistance of guerilla warfare.[18] Does this opposition then not correspond to what we have previously identified as a distinction between the named (or

[18] Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, *Multitude*, New York: Penguin, 2005, 45.

institutionalized) action and the blooming, buzzing confusion of scene, from which as yet no formalizable actantial categories have emerged? This category may also stand in constitutive opposition to what we have called the existential experience of war, through which an equally undefined subject or consciousness finds representation. But Scene is in its fullest reality necessarily collective, and it is the multiplicity of the collective which marks the difference between the representational problems we have rehearsed here. The language of the existential individual already possesses an elaborate history with all kinds of stereotypes that it can be the task of representation to correct, disrupt, undermine or metaphysically challenge. That of the collective does not yet exist. Group, nation, clan, class, general will, multitude—all these remain so many linguistic experiments for designating an impossible collective totality, a manifold of consciousnesses as unimaginable as it is real. War is one among such collective realities which exceed representation fully as much as they do conceptualization, and yet which ceaselessly tempts and exasperates narrative ambitions, conventional and experimental alike.

As for the thing itself, to minimize its horrors is to pass for callous or historically privileged, and in any case naive; yet to insist on its elimination as the central task of politics is willfully to ignore or to condone the immemorial record of peacetime oppression which is the burden of class history. To paraphrase Horkheimer on fascism, he who would not mention capitalism and class struggle has nothing to say about war. The concept of violence is an ideology, however real its existence. Nor should we underestimate its ambiguity, and in particular its potential excitement. I think it was John Aldridge who pointed out that the powerful anti-war novels written in the wake of World War I to warn their readers occasionally had the opposite effect, fascinating young people bored and frustrated by peacetime. Meanwhile, the beginning of a war has often been a source of collective elation, as with World War I in particular.[19]

[19] Here is Robert Musil on what he called "the August experience":

> Those for whom the nation simply does not exist make it too easy for themselves. This mentality, which declares itself extraterritorial and supranational in the name of the spirit, pursues ostrich politics in response to the contempt and slavery that weigh on all of us. This way of thinking sticks its head in the sand, but cannot prevent the blows meant for us all from striking it where its ostrich feathers are. This individualistic, separatist spirit overlooks something else: that well-known summer experience of 1914, the so-called upbeat to a Great Age, and I do not at all mean this entirely ironically. On the contrary, what was

And what of Hegel's infamous remark that war is the health of nations? I would like to think he meant something else and something more than this fleeting experience of the transformation of the nation into an all-too-ephemeral Utopian collectivity. I believe he had in mind the destruction of immense quantities of capital which war brings with it. In our system, the accumulation of undestroyed capital, unproductive, and in the hands of wealthy fanatics and obsessives who are free to use it in the perpetuation of their own privileges, is a burden it is very difficult indeed for a people, even a democratic one, to overcome. I would like to think that Hegel meant the demolition of all that and the possibility for a poor and laborious society of survivors to begin again. André Gide thought that convalescence from illness was one of the most precious human experiences. In that case, not the exhilaration of the beginning of a war, but the collective convalescence that sets in with its conclusion is the better meaning of Hegel's sentence.

stammered at the outset and later allowed to degenerate into a cliché—that the war was a strange, somehow religious experience—undoubtedly corresponds to a fact; that it degenerated says nothing against the character of the original insight. It became a cliché in the customary way precisely because we called it a religious experience, and in doing so gave it an archaizing mask, instead of asking what it actually *was* that was pounding so strangely and violently on a realm of ideas and feelings that had been asleep for the longest time. Still, it cannot be denied that mankind (and of course people in all countries in the same way) was touched at that time by something irrational and foolish, but awesome, that was alien, not from the familiar earth, and which therefore, even before the actual disillusionments of war arrived, had already been declared a hallucination or a ghost simply because its atmospherically undefined nature prevented it from being held or grasped.

Contained in this perception too was the intoxicating feeling of having, for the first time, something in common with every German. One suddenly became a tiny particle humbly dissolved in a suprapersonal event and, enclosed by the nation, sensed the nation in an absolutely physical way. It was as if mystical primal qualities that had slept through the centuries imprisoned in a word had suddenly awakened to become as real as factories and offices in the morning. One would have to have a short memory, or an elastic conscience, to bury this insight under later reflection.

Robert Musil, "'Nation' as Ideal and as Reality," in *Precision and Soul: Essays and Addresses*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1990, 102–3.

Chapter III

The Historical Novel Today, Or, Is It Still Possible?

Greifst in ein fremdestes Bereich,
Machst frevelhaft am Ende neue Schulden,
Denkst Helenen so leicht hervorzurufen
Wie das Papiergespenst der Gulden.
Goethe, *Faust*, Part II

Even in the throne room scene, Mephistopheles reminded the future treasure-hunters of the proximity of the underworld. For the treasures abandoned and forgotten by History ... await their rediscoverers like the historical figures in Hades. What the past buried and hid away, the present seeks to resurrect, if only as the deceptive image of what they imagine the past to have been. There is thus an archaeological dimension to all these seemingly so different appearances: conjuration or treasure hunt replace excavation, reality hesitates uncertainly between the offerings of magic and the value of paper money.
Heinz Schlaffer

Perry Anderson, in his landmark survey of the genre,[1] reminds us that the historical novel has never been so popular nor so abundantly produced as at the present time: an assertion that seems counterintuitive in the light of present-day enfeeblement of historical consciousness and a sense of the past only until you grasp that production as symptom and as symbolic compensation.

But what kind of historical novel is being reproduced here? Harlequin "histories," in which a romantic tale is played out against this or that costume setting? *Annales*-school reconstruction of the peculiar mores and customs of a selected segment of the past? The attempt faithfully to reconstruct the historical situation in which this or that "real" historical figure made his fateful decision? The "feel" of

[1] Perry Anderson, "From Progress to Catastrophe," *London Review of Books* 33:15 (July 2011).

a great event (Pompei, the conquistadors arriving on the shore of the New World) through the eyes of an imaginary character (one probably doomed to reproduce the movements of this or that sub-generic plot paradigm at least as stereotypical as the "romance" with which we began this enumeration)? The historical novel seems doomed to make arbitrary selections from the great menu of the past, so many differing and colorful segments or periods catering to the historicist taste, and all now, in full globalization, more or less equal in value (or a Ranke liked to say, "immediate to God"). Meanwhile, as for the protagonists, they are also by now more or less equivalent: Julius Caesar, Huang Di, Genghis Khan, Stalin, Shaka—take your choice depending on your mood of the day, in that reflecting the now ambiguous and imperiled status of the individual subject or identity, no longer centered or unified, and capable of breaking down into so many distinct subject-positions (let alone confronting its own extinction, as in the famous poststructuralist "death of the subject"). How to have confidence in the presence and stability of any of the allegedly world-historical figures of the past when we have lost our own? In short, we have to do here, as with realism, with an impossible form or genre that, as Anderson suggests, is still assiduously practiced.

But this may well be an excellent reason for arousing further suspicions about this genre, which has so often been marshaled to serve political ends, of which nationalism is only the most obvious. Yet the inventor of the modern form itself, often thought to be at one with his narrative persona—the Scottish antiquarian and collector of anecdotal folk materials (as other contemporaries collected fairy tales and folksongs)—had in fact a more complex, if no less ideological agenda—namely the production of Britishness and of the new identity-concept of "Britain." As for the greatest American novelist of the last century, his testimony to the experience of defeat is placed in a more ambiguous light by the pioneering demonstration by Peter Novick that having lost the Civil War, the South then successfully conquered the academic profession of history in the US,[2] opening the floodgates of a nostalgia no less toxic than that of a postwar British celebration of the good old class system or of the Raj. Is it possible, then, that a socially levelled and plebeianized population finds fantasy gratification in images of hierarchical social relations and by-gone systems of privilege? Meanwhile, Harlequin romances and the like

[2] Peter Novick, *That Noble Dream*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988.

suggest that such settings are also propitious to libidinal fantasies and wish-fulfillments as well, so that the historical novel proves formally adequate to gender as well as to class needs (let alone racist ones). A genre of this kind demands an ideological testing system a good deal more complex than what the everyday reader would instinctively bring to the celebration of other people's heroes and historical moments of heroic resistance, defeat or even triumph. Today, when the rhetoric of the nation has largely been supplanted by that of small groups (of whatever variety), we may be excused for wondering what such a tainted form can legitimately do for us.

Meanwhile, victory and its triumphalistic celebrations have everywhere fallen under a cloud, as it is assumed that winners, always instantly corrupted, turn into the "state" in no time. The conviction that revolutions are always confiscated, when not already defeated, then inspires, not an effort to rethink and revitalize the concept of revolution as such, but rather the glamorization of testimony and memory and the fetishization of so-called "*lieux de mémoire*." The Holocaust industry ought then to offer renewed legitimation for the historical novel as a form,[3] except that oral histories and local documentation, massively in place, would preempt the fictional were it not already paralyzed by the formal problem of narrating the collective.

In the previous essay, we simplified Kenneth Burke's "dramatistic pentad" into an opposition between act and agency on the one hand and scene on the other, thereby finding that we had ended up merely reproducing a time-honored and philosophically stigmatized opposition between subject and object that no one has any great interest in perpetuating. But this reluctance has less to do with the form of the binary opposition as such, than with its omission of a fundamental element in the scheme, a missing third in all these definitions and conflicts, which is simply the collectivity as such. We may let Brecht's great poem on dynastic change in traditional societies evoke its unseen omnipresence:

> When the houses of the great collapse
> many little ones are slain.
> Those who had no share in the fortunes of the mighty
> often share in their misfortunes.
> The plunging wagon drags

[3] See footnote 39 below for a brief discussion of just such a historical novel.

the sweating oxen with it
into the abyss.[4]

Individual and collectivity are here opposed in the persons of lord and subject, but each are opposed in different ways to Scene, in the sense of the mode of production in which this class struggle takes form (here the so-called Asiatic mode, today that of capitalism). It is tempting to characterize the historical novel as the intersection between individual existence and History, the lightning bolt of wars and revolutions that suddenly strikes a peaceful village or an urban daily life. I have myself elsewhere borrowed the Heideggerian formula that expresses the simultaneous emergence and withdrawal of Being, in order to characterize texts which, in one way or another, and exceptionally, "make History appear," no matter how fitfully.[5] Unfortunately for literary theory, such texts do not always have to be historical novels. Indeed, as we will see later on, the most eminent theorist of the historical novel (Georg Lukács) is led by his commitment to the representational glimpse of deeper underlying historical trends and tendencies (the future of society secretly at work within its present) to the implicit conclusion that our true historical novel, today, is not the historical novel at all but rather realism as such.

So if we want to keep the novel "historical," it looks as though we will be forced back upon our subject/object alternative and obliged in spite of ourselves to make a choice between some dated and named Event in history (Savonarola's downfall, the Sicilian Expedition, Napoleon's invasion of Russia) and that more general scenic thing which is a historical period, a setting or a culture (Tenochtitlan, the era of the whaling ships, some far future dystopia, or New York in the 1950s), all of which we tend to visualize spatially rather than temporally.

But inasmuch as History also has a history, the ratio between these poles will vary considerably ever since its quasi-invention around the time of the French Revolution. Before that, the chronicle of the reigns of kings and queens (which passed for historiography) left little room for difference and social or cultural change, for historicity or historicism, a form of consciousness that

[4] Bertolt Brecht, "Der Kaukasische Kreidekreis," *Grosse Kommentierte Berliner und Frankfurter Ausgabe*, Berlin: Suhrkamp, 1992, Vol. 8, 107 (Scene 1), trans. mine.

[5] In the last chapter of my *Valences of the Dialectic*, London: Verso, 2010.

may be said to date from the "Querelle des anciens et des modernes" (1687–1714).[6]

But the kings and queens, dynastic history, certainly outlived the chronicles, and in the form of those protagonists nobler than ourselves (as Northrop Frye, following Aristotle, might put it), and under the guise of what Hegel infamously called "world-historical individuals," they dominated the historical novel at least until more modern forms of nationalism—the allegorical protagonists of the nation and the people—took their place, and the lower classes of peasantry and proletariat began to make sporadic appearances.

The great modern ideological leaders (or dictators) then appeared at the very moment in which historiography began to doubt its own anthropomorphic methods, and to project *Annales*-style accounts of the past that did away with narrative actors altogether. The calling into question of the category of the Event, however, scarcely leaves the historical novel without any reason for being, since it can then energetically assume the task of dismantling all the inherited illusions, beginning with those having to do with the historical heroes themselves and their "victories." So we have protagonists in whom we no longer believe, and masses who are at best imaginary, and to this unpromising material we bring our incredulity about the grand narratives of decisive events and genuine historical change or development. What seems to survive at best are a host of names and an endless warehouse of images. What kind of History can the contemporary historical novel then be expected to "make appear"?

1.

What is most frequently retained from the essays of *The Historical Novel*[7] is the distinction between the world-historical individual and the average hero, a formal and structural opposition derived from Scott's *Waverley* (1811), on most accounts the first modern historical novel, and certainly the model of most of what was done in this vein in the first half of the nineteenth century as well as the paradigm of the most fertile operatic tradition. Paradoxically, the two greatest

[6] Hans-Robert Jauss, *Studien zum Epochenwandel der äesthetischen Moderne*, Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1990.

[7] Georg Lukács, *The Historical Novel*, trans. Hannah and Stanley Mitchell, Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1983; page numbers in text refer to this edition.

historical novels of the period seem neither of them to obey this formula, as we shall see; we will return to them later.

What is less often noticed about Lukács' discussion is first, that what underpins his proposed opposition is the generic distinction between the theater and the novel; and second, that in the course of it, Scott's own paradigm vanishes, giving way to Balzac, who writes, not historical novels, but contemporary novels which are profoundly historical. A Hegelian *Aufhebung* is then at work here, and the historical novel of Scott becomes the vehicle for a historicization of the novel in general, which leaves the specialized sub-genre called the "historical novel" as a kind of evolutionary dead end for the rest of the (bourgeois) century after 1848, only to revive, but far more weakly, in the era of the popular front. It turns out, then, that despite appearances, Lukács is not really interested in the historical novel at all, but rather in the novel as such, in realism and the realistic novel, which when it comes into its own will be profoundly historical and will let History appear more effectively than its earlier, more specialized vehicle.

This can all be said in a different way by attention to the ways in which the content of a given historical moment enables or limits its representational form, or better still, its narrative possibilities. The tension, in Marxism and elsewhere in social thought generally, between sociology and history, or better still, between structure and the event, between everyday life and its cultural continuities and the cataclysm of a genuinely historical turning point or paradigm shift—this tension, which we will confront as a genuine opposition or formal alternative in the next section, also makes possible moments in which the two kinds of realities overlap, and in which therefore complex or dual possibilities are momentarily available.

This overlap explains the privileged situation of Scott in Lukács' system, for his focus on a specific kind of historical catastrophe allows him to write a kind of social description of the past as well as to single out a historical event. This involves his relationship to what is translated as "gentile" society and social relations. The reader today will probably first find religious-sectarian associations flashing up at the use of this word, which however has nothing to do with non-Jews and everything to do with the *gens*, that precapitalist society explored by Morgan in *Ancient Society* (still a fundamental work in the Marxian canon), and there represented by the Iroquois. The society of the gens (or "gentile society") is a clan-based society which is neither feudal

nor organized according to the contentious category of "oriental despotism" or the so-called Asiatic mode of production. It is closer to Tacitus's Germans and is thereby relatively more democratic and perhaps closer to the simpler groups ranged under primitive communism, which, coming out of pre-agricultural hunters-and-gatherers, are organized by gender and by age (the elders having priority in decisions and distribution of goods). These classificatory uncertainties account for the springing up of further categories of modes of production within the standard ones (four or five from primitive communism to socialism) and very much include the nomadic societies dear to Deleuze and Guattari[8] and perhaps most extensively theorized by Owen Lattimore.[9] Clan society is another one of these developmental routes, and obviously in the world of Sir Walter Scott it is embodied in the Gaelic highlanders, whose social order is extinguished by the genocide which followed the end of the 1745 uprising and the battle of Culloden. Scott is, as we shall see, and whatever his other political sympathies, the epic poet of the end of this mode of production.

But its pre-bourgeois or pre-capitalist social relations are then those of the epic as such, and they thus entitle Scott to a characterological and literary identification which, far from being a deficiency and a defect, turns out to be one of his strengths. At this point, therefore, the investigation will seek less to differentiate epic from novel but momentarily to draw them closer together. "Scott's historical subject-matter ... is linked not with his interest in history as such, but with the specific nature of his historical themes, with his selection of those periods and those strata of society which embody the old epic self-activity of man, the old epic directness of social life, its public spontaneity. This it is that makes Scott a great epic portrayer of the 'age of heroes,' the age from which the true epic grows, in the sense of Vico and Hegel" (35). In fact, the analysis here is taken directly from Hegel (Lukács has already discussed his analysis of epic); and this residuality and survival (in both content and form) will be a crucial indication for a rereading of Scott according to different categories and standards than those of the novel as a successor and replacement of epic.

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[8] Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *The Anti-Oedipus* (see chapter 3: "Savages, Barbarians, Civilized"), Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1989.

[9] Owen Lattimore, *The Inner Asian Frontiers of China*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1989 [1940].

In one sense, then, Scott confirms our obscure suspicion that all genuinely historical novels must have a revolutionary moment as their occasion: a moment of radical change, which lifts their content out of the placid continuities of mere custom and of the picturesque daily life of this or that exotic moment of the past. The implication is then that all great historical novelists must in one way or another harbor conservative sympathies, and have a deep ontological investment in the old ways of life in the process of being destroyed by the new order, whether that be the new English hegemony over the Scots or that of the Normans over the Anglo-Saxons, the emergent post-revolutionary capitalism of Balzac's Restoration (in name only), the encroaching Europeans of Fenimore Cooper, or indeed all those later capitalist industrialisms which destroy village life and tradition, or even the seemingly eternal American small town. The protagonists of these later revolutions—Zola's Saccard or even Faulkner's Snopses—are from this perspective rarely seen as world-historical individuals in Hegel's sense, for in Hegel this kind of figure consciously or unconsciously prepared the future and epitomized a kind of historical progress that the conservative historical novelists reject. For them, the world-historical figures are the heroes who fail, who succumb fighting against history, like the Pretender in *Waverley*; and it may be suggested that wherever a vision of history embodies this struggle between past and future in a way that approaches the radical dichotomy of class struggle and genuine revolution, the text and its characters are likely to take on an allegorical function.

Still, the prototypical content of historical novels has always been war, about which we will affirm that to the degree to which its representation is authentically historical in Lukács' sense, it will always be in one way or another a figure for class struggle as such. The greatest historical novels of this first period, however—Scott's *Heart of Midlothian* and Manzoni's *Betrothed*—do not have warfare as their central object of representation; and they also offer more specific hints as to the uses and formal function of the world-historical figures we have been discussing here. In *The Heart of Midlothian*, for example, the world-historical individual appears only in the final meeting with the Duke of Argyle (one of the great historical mediators between England and Scotland in the period of the Union and the 1715 invasion); in Manzoni, it takes the form of the archbishop, whose ministrations are in many ways the climax of the narrative, which almost literally moves towards him with much the same momentum

as Jeannie's voyage south to seek the King's pardon for her sister. This confers on the narrative the great spatial and geographical form of the adventure as such, which unites the episodic and the linear, looping the melodramatic elements back into epic movement. Lukács specifies the limits of Manzoni's novel wrongly, in my opinion, by identifying Italy's historic dilemma as that of unification. (Machiavelli is often interpreted as turning on this issue, which is rather the production of the nation as such.) One might say the same about *Midlothian*, insofar as the unification of England and Scotland is at its center, overlaid by the twin contradictions of a tripartite class system (highlanders, lowland Scots and English) and a tripartite religious and ideological struggle (between the Anglican Church, the Presbyterians and the Cameronians—these last the remnants of the radical Calvinists). But to give contradiction a physical and spatial form, and to enlarge the province of the novel to include geography, are obviously both essential components in the invention of this genre, in which time becomes space and the past is transformed into the sensory and the visible.

Meanwhile, in both works, the collective, and that even rarer and more unique event which is Revolution, replaces the relatively specialized background of war itself by way of the social content shared by each, namely masses of people in aggressive protest and demonstration. These "mob uprisings"—the Porteus riots in Scott, a protest against a brutal police officer, and the bread riots in Manzoni—then stand as figures of the collective and of revolution against the state and against the old order: transparent figures, which the Queen is not slow to interpret as resistance to the Union itself, even though her Scottish subjects (and no doubt Scott himself) go to some lengths to minimize the political meaning of this disturbance organized by mere agitators. The historical novel as a genre cannot exist without this dimension of collectivity, which marks the drama of the incorporation of individual characters into a greater totality, and can alone certify the presence of History as such. Without this collective dimension, history, one is tempted to say, is again reduced to mere conspiracy, the form it takes in novels which have aimed for historical content without historical consciousness and which remain therefore merely political in some more specialized sense.

What must also be emphasized is that the named historical figure, the so-called world-historical individual, already exists: "we do not follow his life step by step; we see him only at moments when he is

significant" (Otto Ludwig, quoted by Lukács, 45). The events with which he is associated have already happened, they are fixed, however one wishes to reinterpret them. In that sense, the world-historical figure is the result of prior knowledge: a name familiar from the school books, as they pass the various official versions of national and international history on down to successive generations. Our approach to them must therefore include a kind of voyeuristic curiosity: so this is how they looked and acted! This is how they spoke to their subordinates (or their superiors)! These were their reactions on hearing the news or on confronting a crisis! And so forth: such prior knowledge is absolutely required (for we approach the unknown heroes of other people's history only by analogy), and it is also what determines Lukács' positioning of them in drama. For as opposed to the "totality of objects" central to the epic, drama stages the moments of decision of these already familiar historical actors themselves, which it must necessarily stage from the outside, if necessary by way of the great monologues and soliloquies. The agonies of their decisions remain alive before us on stage, but the outcomes cannot be changed, we know the facts in advance from our history books. Whence the problematic transfer of such figures to the novel, where stream of consciousness and interior monologue ought to provide an even closer approach to subjectivities which must however forever remain closed and mysterious. When Tolstoy provides us with an account of Napoleon's thoughts, the results must always be derisory (we note that he is careful not to show us Kutuzov's stream of consciousness). Clearly, then, the famous "average hero" whose presence Lukács posits as a necessary mediation between everyday life and the great historical events is precisely the theatrical spectator, who observes the great episodically and from afar.

Yet we must also understand that this "rule" of historical fiction is part and parcel of a whole Lukácsian attack on biography as a form (André Maurois is singled out as a particularly egregious specimen of this new twentieth century bourgeois decadence)[10] and testifies to his

[10] Oddly enough, Lukács does not here include the most ancient warning of this kind, in Aristotle's *Poetics*, paragraph 8: "The unity of plot does not consist, as some suppose, in its having one man as its subject. An infinity of things befall that one man, some of which it is impossible to reduce to unity; and in like manner there are many actions of one man which cannot be made to form one action." (*Aristotle's Rhetoric and Poetics*, trans. W. Rhys Roberts and Ingram Bywater, New York: Random House, 1954, 234.)

conviction that subjective analysis and interpretation of characters—fictive or historical—inevitably leads to the pathological, just as the modern (bourgeois) taste in events tends towards violence and the atrocity. (We may of course in turn psychologize Lukács himself on the basis of his hostility to psychoanalysis.) I will in a moment suggest that this aversion to psychologism risks overlooking one important political function of the historical novel; but it might also be interpreted as a reaction to the more general subjectivization which leads in the modern period to a problematization of narrative itself.

Meanwhile, we need to return for another moment to Scott, whose defense by Lukács ("the classical form of narrative must be shielded against modern prejudices" [40]) is reinforced by just such attacks on the interest in complex psychological states and on the taste for the violent and the exotic. Lukács does not provide anything like a political analysis of Scott's own historical situation; indeed at some point he calls him an "English" writer, by which one assumes that this Hungarian intellectual writing in German means only to designate the language of the texts (but one might have some difficulty in sustaining even this in a discussion of *The Heart of Midlothian*, for example). At any rate, it is important to stress the room for manoeuver afforded Scott by the three-sided situation of an opposition between highland and lowland Scots confronted by the English overlord: of these, it is only the highlanders who constitute that "gentile society" in the course of extermination, nor do the recent theorists of Scottish devolution ever claim Scott for any cultural resistance to English assimilation.[11] What they do point out is that his literary operation—whatever else it may be as a vision of history—is also an ideological one, namely the construction of a Britishness in which the lowland Scot can henceforth coexist with the English as a single entity: and to that degree the royal pardon at the end of *The Heart of Midlothian* is as ideological a gesture as the handshake between labor and capital that concludes Fritz Lang's *Metropolis*.

To be sure, Lukács is not a practitioner of ideological critique, despite the theoretical innovations of *History and Class Consciousness*;[12] indeed, one misunderstands the whole thrust of his "Marxist literary criticism" if one does not understand that he is there attempting to

[11] See Robert Crawford, *Devolving English Literature*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1992.

[12] See my discussion in *Valences of the Dialectic*.

substitute a Marxist formalism for Soviet class-affiliated literary judgements of the current 1930s. Still, it seems to me that we do not fully grasp Scott's narrative possibilities (or Balzac's either) if we remain content with Engels's famous formulations on the way in which the conservative Balzac is nonetheless forced by history to write against himself.[13]

Perhaps the problem of class affiliation may be approached in another way by observing that the moment of revolution—the absolute Event, so to speak[14]—is always a matter of absolute dichotomization: whatever happens later on, the "lyric illusion" is always the moment in which everyone has to take sides, for or against, and that this stark simplification then poses unique dilemmas for

[13] Friedrich Engels, letter to Margaret Harkness, April 1888: "The more opinions of the author remain hidden, the better for the work of art. The realism I allude to may crop out even in spite of the author's opinions. Let me refer to an example. Balzac whom I consider a far greater master of realism than all the Zolas *passés, présents et à venir*, in *La Comédie humaine* gives us a most wonderfully realistic history of French "society," describing, chronicle-fashion, almost year by year from 1816 to 1848 the progressive inroads of the rising bourgeoisie upon the society of nobles that reconstituted itself after 1815 and that set up again, as far as it could, the standard of *la vieille politesse francaise*. He describes how the last remnants of this, to him, model society gradually succumbed before the intrusion of the vulgar moneyed upstart, or were corrupted by him; how the *grande dame* whose conjugal infidelities were but a mode of asserting herself in perfect accordance with the way she had been disposed of in marriage, gave way to the bourgeoisie, who cornered her husband for cash or cashmere; and around this central picture he groups a complete history of French society from which, even in economic details (for instance the re-arrangement of real and personal property after the Revolution) I have learned more than from all the professed historians, economists and statisticians of the period together. Well, Balzac was politically a Legitimist; his great work is a constant elegy on the irretrievable decay of good society, his sympathies are all with the class doomed to extinction. But for all that his satire is never keener, his irony never bitterer, than when he sets in motion the very men and women with whom he sympathises most deeply—the nobles. And the only men of whom he always speaks with undisguised admiration, are his bitterest political antagonists, the republican heroes of the Cloître Saint-Méry, the men, who at that time (1830–36) were indeed the representatives of the popular masses. That Balzac thus was compelled to go against his own class sympathies and political prejudices, that he *saw* the necessity of the downfall of his favourite nobles, and described them as people deserving no better fate; and that he *saw* the real men of the future where, for the time being, they alone were to be found—that I consider one of the greatest triumphs of realism and one of the grandest features in old Balzac."

[14] I take Alain Badiou's philosophical and political work as turning centrally around the analysis of revolution as absolute Event.

narrative representation. An analogy may be made (and is often made in practice if not in theory) with the representational problems of war, about which Lukács quotes Balzac with approval: "It is impossible for literature to go beyond a certain limit in painting the facts of war" (he recommends that writers confine themselves to "small encounters, revealing through them the spirit of the two contending masses") (43).

Leaving aside the question of whether there have ever been successful revolutions in the first place, we may suggest that an absolute dichotomization, which leaves only two adversaries face to face, leads at once to a kind of allegorical treatment unsuitable to the novel as a form and presenting impossible obstacles for any genuinely novelistic narration. (For one thing, it then becomes impossible for either one of the opposing sides to avoid taking the role of the villain—a category of melodrama rather than of realism, let alone historical realism; and it will be remembered that the greatest historical works—Malraux's *l'Espoir*, where the principle is articulated explicitly, or Peter Weiss's *Äesthetik des Widerstandes*—deliberately avoid any account of the other side, in this case Spanish fascism or Nazism respectively.)

Is it still possible that the word revolution is historically and even dialectically ambiguous? That what we call a revolution in the passage from the old order or feudalism to capitalism is not at all the same structurally or substantively as the passage from capitalism to a post-capitalist or revolutionary order? And this, despite the continuing existence of capitalist urban elements (in Czarist Russia and pre-revolutionary China) alongside feudal ones—peasantries, landlords and the like? In other words, to use the same word, revolution, for historically different transitions from one mode of production to another is to suggest an identity between them which is misleading, despite the absence of different words for these different transitions (as in the various Inuit words for snow or the various Arabic words for sand).[15] This ambiguity suggests some doubt as to whether the historical novel—historically a narrative form generated by the passage from the old order to a bourgeois society, as well as the representation of that historical passage—can function as a useful generic category for novels which issue from and represent wholly different kinds of historical convulsions. This does not mean that revolutions

[15] But now see, for the most exhaustive discussion of this problem, Neil Davidson, *How Revolutionary were the Bourgeois Revolutions?*, Chicago: Haymarket, 2012.

are henceforth impossible, or that history is at an end, or that capitalism is eternal; only that our use of the generic term is metaphorical or even analogical, and demands the most vigilant suspicion as we go along.

At any rate, the historical novel, condemned to such unique raw material, will demand a multiplicity and differentiation of standpoints, in such a way that the Event itself is grasped on either side of its absolute moment, either in the multiplicity of class positions that precede the revolutionary moment, or in the dispersal that follows its repression.

This clarifies the advantages of Scott's three-sided situation, which is replicated in the novel in the "average hero's" distance from both the English and the Jacobite positions. But perhaps it may also be well to open a parenthesis here on the question of parties or factions in such situations: for it is clear that later anti-political novelists such as Flaubert will use the multiplicity of parties and factions as a demonstration of the vacuity of revolution itself, as in the great assemblies of the political clubs in *L'Éducation sentimentale*,[16] as artfully grotesque as anything in Daumier. When we reach this stage of a babel of political opinions, what has happened is that the "political," hitherto a convulsive stirring of the Event as such and an eruption of History, has become specialized as subject matter, and points ahead to those institutionalized genres which deal with parliamentary or representational dramas and characters (as in Trollope). The debates on the Communist Party in modern literature (from Malraux to Weiss) are debates within socialism (generally written by party sympathizers or former adherents rather than current members), and thus are not to be classified as novels about the flora and fauna of a specific institution, and not representations of revolution as such.

But now we need to assess the promotion of Balzac to Scott's legatee as the archetypal representative of the historical novelist, when in fact he wrote so few such works (and there is little reason to rate *Les Chouans* any higher than Hugo's *Quatre-vingt-treize*, for example). The dialectical argument will consist in positing a transformation of the historical novel into the novel in general and as such (and the confluence of an English eighteenth-century social novel without historical focus into a form social and historical all at once). In Balzac, all novels are historical novels, or, to put it another way,

[16] See "The Experiments of Time" above in this volume.

when a standpoint has been reached in which the present can itself be apprehended as history, a novel set in any of the periods through which the author himself lived, from the Restoration to 1848, can be said to qualify as a "historical novel" in the generic sense. Scott's tripartite situation is then here reproduced in an oddly asymmetrical way. For besides the two sides in conflict during the Revolution (and setting the romantically ambiguous figure of Napoleon aside), the ostensible winners of the revolutionary struggle, the aristocrats who return to power during the Restoration, are in fact in Balzac's eyes the true losers, since they are politically incompetent and—mostly provincial—are destitute, while the beneficiaries of the revolution (those who bought church properties for example) remain in place. This is, indeed, as Lukács liked to point out (following Engels), why the one true revolutionary hero in Balzac—the martyr of the 1832 uprising, Michel Chrestien—is on the left, and an opponent of the "bourgeois monarchy" fully as much as the Bourbons.[17]

It may be worth devoting a little more thought to this unique position of Balzac in literary history and in the history of the historical novel. Why should we consider Balzac's novels more profoundly historical than Stendhal's *Charterhouse of Parma*, for example, the very epitome of the historical novel, with its popular uprisings, its court intrigues, its despots, and its Napoleonic and post-Napoleonic background? Indeed, was not Stendhal himself the very theorist of the political novel, with his slogan—a pistol shot in the middle of a concert?

The comparison incites us to two questions, the first of which has to do with the obvious absence of mob scenes in Balzac's most characteristic works, that is, the absence of that collective dimension we have affirmed to be essential to the form. The second is the absence of the Event, even though, to be sure, all of Balzac's novels document the consequences of that Event which is the Revolution (and its Napoleonic world sequel). I think that collectivity is in Balzac figured by Paris itself (or its force of gravity on the rest of France in the provincial novels). Paris, the indispensable center of revolution in French history, and the unique space around which all of French social life turns (unlike other European capital cities or great metropolises, such as London), figures the collective totality in ways not available to

[17] This fictional "world-historical protagonist" appears off stage in the novella "Les Secrets de la Princess de Cadignan," for Lukács (as well as for Engels) one of the most revealing moments in *La Comédie humaine*.

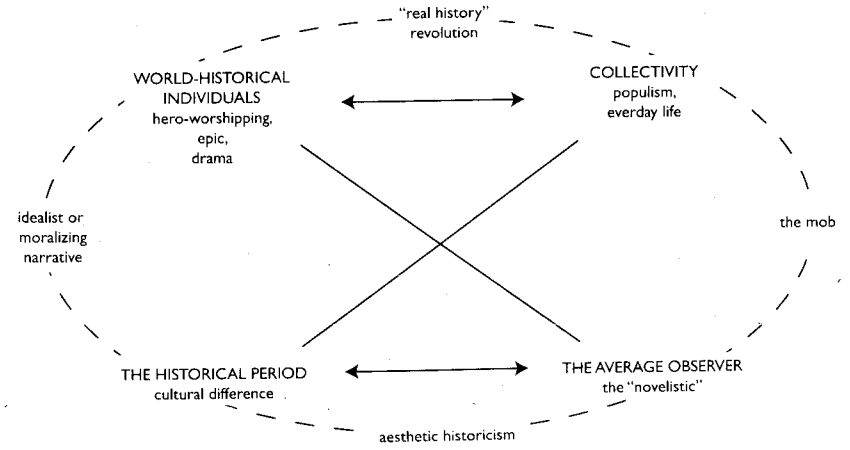
other novelists. Meanwhile, the fact that the action of Balzac's novels is always dated—we always have to do with the 1830s or '40s, with the Restoration period, and that not in general but in the annual specifications of their changes, their fashions, their power systems—is what links them to the great "axial events" as it were (Ricoeur's expression) which constitute History itself in its more specific sense. This is what Dickens's novels lack, inasmuch as there is in modern English history no such axial event from which to date the fictional action (in George Eliot, to be sure, it is the moment of the Reform Bill which is selected as a historical center and which lends her work its greater historicity); and as for Galdós, there is always the Revolution of 1867 which we approach and from which we recede in significantly more historicist fashion. Tolstoy is of course, as we shall see later, diverted from his "axial event" by the failure of the Decembrist rebellion (which was to have been the official subject of *War and Peace*). But French history is unique in its punctuation by crucial revolutionary moments (which could be prolonged into the twentieth century by the Popular Front, the Liberation of Paris, May '68), which confer a profound historicity even onto the most inconspicuous of peacetime years. (Sartre's little fable is instructive: when the Second World War broke out, he says, our entire youth was reified into a period called "*l'entre-deux-guerres*").

With Balzac's formal transformation, then, the historical novel in its earlier authenticity disappears; its place taken by "realism"; but what particularly interests us here is that by the same token, the world-historical individual also disappears: Michel Chrestien, a fictive character, takes his place; later on, but off-stage, Rastignac becomes prime minister, however much his death in the plague resembles that of Casimir Perier; various figures represent Fouchet or Talleyrand, but Napoleon is absent from *Une ténébreuse affaire*, save for his fatal decision, etc. Political intrigue and the dialectical complexity of revolutionary and post-revolutionary French political history have not disappeared, but the great historical actors have been effaced to the benefit of the period itself, which comes to the forefront as social reality rather than historical event.

But to be sure, the genre itself survives, now emptied of its genuine historical content; and we may follow it on through its next stages as Lukács sees them (the true historical novel living on briefly outside of France in Cooper and Manzoni and Pushkin, as well as in the special case of Tolstoy to whom we will come later on). What happens

as historiography itself becomes theorized in terms of class struggle, first on the right by its ideologues, and then on the liberal left by Thierry and novelists like Merimée, Vigny, and Hugo, is that the world-historical individual again occupies center stage and the form is undermined by a dialectical opposition between "picturesquely fashioned anecdotes" (the empirical facts) and "moral reflections," the political and ideological judgements of the authors (77). "Merimée wishes to draw general lessons from history which hold good for all time (including the present) but he draws them *directly* from a keen and detailed observation of the empirical facts of history" (79), which is to say that he does not grasp either "history" or its "lessons" historically, and as a result these well-meaning and moralizing or idealizing efforts lead on into the decadence of post-1848 literature, of which Flaubert's *Salammbô* is the terrible object lesson, and in which the philosophical and ideological triumph of empiricism leads to decorative exoticism, if not the excesses of violence and atrocities for their own sake. Meanwhile, what was once the authorial judgements of these novels becomes the place of a subjectivity which either surrenders to the pathological and the exceptional or to the reified form of the biographical (if not indeed to both at once).

In effect, this turn spells the extinction of the historical novel as a form until we come to the progressive literature of the twentieth century, whose specimens, from Romain Rolland and de Coster to Feuchtwanger or Heinrich Mann, do not arouse much excitement, even in Lukács. But it will be remembered that the modernism debate casts its shadow over such debates in the contemporary period, just as Stalinist nationalism casts another. Lukács is therefore scarcely in



a position to assess the possibilities of anything like a modernist historical novel, while its possible evolution into a historical novel of the future (just as with Balzac we saw it evolve into a historical novel of the present) is not yet for him conceivable in the state at which socialist construction found itself at the end of his lifetime.

He also failed to note the way in which the historical novel could function as an intervention into the political situation and not merely a representation of the past. This is something we may observe at work in one of the rare successful novelizations of a genuine revolution, namely Hilary Mantel's *Place of Greater Safety*, which, transgressing all the Lukácsian warnings and injunctions, offers a remarkable picture of the lives and psychologies and personal and social relations of the three major actors of the French Revolution itself—namely Camille Desmoulins, Danton and Robespierre. She thereby transfers what is minimally permissible on stage (Büchner's *Dantons Tod*) and psychologizes and presumably modernizes real historical figures, whose thoughts she makes available to us, and this in the form of personal relationships, solidarities, jealousies, envies, and private judgements, which might well have been depoliticized and modernized in the form of this or that intimate novel or play staging purely fictional individuals. The great "events" of the French Revolution here indeed come before us in the form of echoes, rumors, reports from the outside, sounds in the street, documents to be signed or decisions to be made or evaded: as rich as the texture is, there is something of the closet drama about all this and a reduction of the collective dimensions of this unique revolutionary situation, an Event which included many events and truly contained multitudes.

One can indeed prefer to this fictionalization the truly novelistic proportions of Michelet's great history, or indeed the varieties of its contemporary tellings and reinterpretations; indeed, the prior knowledge required here is not only that of the elaborate chronology of the Revolution itself, portrayed as I suggested only in its effects and scarcely in itself and according to its own extraordinary and well-nigh autonomous inner momentum, but also that of the various interpretations themselves, which can mainly be reduced to a taking of sides, now for the monarchists (the Mirabeau of the beginning), now for the Girondins, now (and far more frequently) for the genuinely humanistic populist Danton, and scarcely anyone at all for the prim monster Robespierre—each of whom represent a specific political solution and program.

The taking of sides, the partisanship, generally stops there, as it is assumed that Thermidor effectively answers the question all revolutions ask themselves, namely when the revolution is considered to be at an end. Not only do we have Michelet's extraordinary picture of the emptiness of the assembly on all sides as Robespierre confronts it towards the end of his work of ideological purification. We also have Michelet's coda, one of the most remarkable envois to be found in any histogriographic narratives (the other, quite different, which I do not quote, is to be found on the last page of Vargas Llosa's *War of the End of the World*; and we will have to return to this matter of the "end," if not of history, then of the historical novel, later on):

> Peu de jours après Thermidor, un homme, qui vit encore et qui avait alors dix ans, fut mené par ses parents au théâtre, et à la sortie admira la longue file de voiture brillantes qui, pour une première fois, frappaient ses yeux. Des gens en veste, chapeau bas, disaient aux spectateurs sortants: «Faut-il une voiture, *mon maitre?*» L'enfant ne comprit pas trop ces termes nouveaux. Il se les fit expliquer, et on lui dit seulement qu'il y avait eu un grand changement par la mort de Robespierre.
>
> A few days after Thermidor, a man still living who was ten years old at the time was taken to the theater by his parents, and coming out after the spectacle gazed with amazement on the long row of splendid vehicles waiting for their customers, he had never seen such a thing before. People with coats on, holding their hats respectfully, were asking the emergent theater-goers, "Does *monsieur* require a carriage?" The child could not quite understand this new language, but on inquiring what it meant, he was told only that much had changed with the death of Robespierre.[18]

What Hilary Mantel's novel achieves is a political intervention of a quite unexpected type: she manages to turn Robespierre into a believable character. It is an achievement that transforms our received opinions on *le vraisemblable*, on political intervention, and indeed on Robespierre himself. She has also in passing given us her philosophical opinions on history and revolution, in properly unbelievable dialogue between Danton and Sade, but that is of little moment here.

What counts is that, in keeping with that dramatic and externalizing stage distance we observe in the representation of the world-historical individuals in our history books, the picture we have of Robespierre himself has never been believable (quite unlike the figures of other "tyrants" like Hitler or Stalin, whom we understand only too well,

[18] Jules Michelet, *Histoire de la revolution francaise*, Paris: Gallimard, 2 volumes, 1952, Vol. II, p. 990. English translation, mine.

mainly on account of their fearsomeness). Robespierre is alternately indifferent, aloof, rigid, puritanical, coldly fanatical, or preposterous, comical, a Malvolio without even passion to excuse him, awkward, mocked behind his back, etc., etc. Michelet himself indulges in this mockery, which only Daniel Guérin has managed to endow with any genuine historical irony, when, taking for the end point of the Revolution not Thermidor but Babeuf, he stages Robespierre as an unwitting tool of the new bourgeois order, tossed aside contemptuously when his historic task has been completed and he is no longer required as an agent.[19]

Now it would not seem to be an extraordinary literary feat to rescue such a peculiar personage from the satiric weight of political vilification and the caricature of his personality and private habits; but surely much in the politics of the past as well as the present turns on just such anthropomorphic assessments: the political is the personal, and the identification of violence with the Law becomes even more intolerable when incarnated in so grotesque a figure. To humanize Robespierre, then, to show the moments when he is a friend and even a lover, to turn the susceptibility to flattery into an excusable failing, to show his anguished hesitation at shipping his childhood comrade Desmoulins off to the gallows (indeed, it is by way of a strange new caricature of Camille that much of this neighboring characterization is achieved)—all this makes it possible once more to reconsider Robespierre's more general political strategy with other standards than the traditional humanist ones whereby his "fanatical" ideals are contrasted unfavorably with the all-too-human weaknesses of Danton (whose personal political hesitations are also foregrounded in what allows a reinterpretation of his own role as well.)[20]

All of this implies a different distance from human relationships and personalities than the older humanist sympathies; yet the shift in psychology and evaluation would be inconsequential—or would be more interesting in the context of Mantel's own literary work rather than in the historiography of the Revolution—were it not for the signal fact that with this intervention in the portrayal of Robespierre, his political program can now again be taken seriously. Its watchwords had little to do with economics in a pre-industrial capitalism, but the social and political diagnosis of corruption is surely not without its

[19] Daniel Guérin, *La lutte de classes sous la première république*, Paris: Gallimard, 1946.

[20] On Mantel's presentation, Danton, after the mobilization of the Parisian masses, decides to withdraw from politics into private life, abandoning power to others.

significance today, where the center and the margins of late capitalism alike are predicated on its omnipresent facilitation of business great and small, and where the universal tolerance of corruption tells us more about what is apolitical in our societies than any number of party-oriented opinion polls. In the current absence of any genuinely socialist politics, Robespierre's politics of Virtue may well have something active and constructive to offer us; it is in any case a genuine political intervention to have made it narratively conceivable again, and Mantel has given us a possibility of rethinking the uses of the historical novel in a mode distinct from that of hagiography or the legend of martyrs.

2.

But we have not yet mentioned the work which for most readers constitutes the very summit of what the historical novel can achieve; nor have we examined the unique way in which Tolstoy inherits and confronts the formal problem of the "world-historical individual" in his historical constructions. For Tolstoy not only includes such figures in a good deal more forthright manner than the distance recommended by Lukács (although there are here and there mediatory characters such as Prince Andrew, whose personal life and psychology is however far more vivid and pronounced than Waverley's, or those of any other characters in Scott). Here the opposition between Napoleon and Kutuzov bears a symbolic weight which dispenses Tolstoy from any more rigorous settling of accounts with Westernizers or Slavophiles in his own immediate intellectual environment (and indeed is complicated by the fact that he identifies fully with neither of these positions: we may well wish to remember Lenin's judgement that he made himself into a kind of ideologue of the peasantry and its worldview,[21] even though that is something perhaps more tangible in *Anna Karenina* and in some of the stories than here). Meanwhile, his opinions on these figures, however aberrant, is not without interest either: Perry Anderson has objected strenuously to the transformation of the old reactionary Kutuzov into a culture hero,[22] while any number of admirers of Napoleon will surely have their word to say

[21] V. I. Lenin, "Leo Tolstoy as the Mirror of the Russian Revolution," in *Collected Works*, Vol. XV, Moscow: Progress, 1973.

[22] See note 1 above.

about that particular caricature. Neither of these reinterpretations, in any case, carries the political weight and value of the intervention we have attributed to Mantel's novel.

Tolstoy's most perceptive critic already casts doubt on the standard view of *War and Peace* as the greatest of all historical novels, not only by insisting on the anachronicity of most of the social materials in the novel (which reproduce Tolstoy's own experiences in the 1840s and '50s), but also by insisting on the generic discontinuities within the work, as a combination of the domestic or family novel with the war narrative.[23] Boris Eikhenbaum then adds, significantly, that in the final version a third "genre"—"the philosophy of history"—is added into the mix. This last, introduced here and there but worked up as an independent treatise in the Second Epilogue, is the least popular part of the book for most readers and for the specialists a testimony to the unphilosophical nature of Tolstoy's mind, as it grapples with abstract problems such as determinism and free will, or historical necessity.

I propose, however, to grasp these ruminations as the attempt to solve a properly narratological issue, and as a logical complement to the unique form-problems posed by the historical novel as such. We have indeed from the outset chosen to couple the two unique characteristics of the historical novel: the presence of "world-historical," which is to say "real" historical, individuals, and the concomitant presence, however shadowy, of the collectivity itself—nation, people or multitude—whose "history" is here in question. But we have linked these two features (which can be omitted from definitions of the novel as such and its other sub-genres) as opposites, whose tension makes up the specificity of this form and on whose resolution depends the literary value and distinctiveness of the work in question. It will therefore be to this second feature of the historical novel—the problem of the representation of collectivity—that we turn in this second section; and it is in this context that Tolstoy's Second Epilogue takes on its narratological significance. Contrary to received opinion, then, we will argue that the relationship of the two great leaders—Napoleon and Kutuzov—to their respective collectivities is not at all an allegorical one, nor is either identified with his "people" or "culture" (what to call this collective background is very much a part of the problem we want to raise here, and we will return to it): indeed, read closely it becomes clear that Tolstoy works hard to exclude this identification on both sides.

[23] Boris Eikhenbaum, *Tolstoi in the Sixties*, Ann Arbor: Ardis, 1982, 242–3.

The way this exclusion is achieved on the French side is obvious enough from episodes such as this one, in which Napoleon receives a Russian emissary:

> It was plain that Balashov's personality did not interest him at all. Evidently only what took place within his own mind interested him. Nothing outside himself had any significance for him, because everything in the world, it seemed to him, depended entirely on his will.[24]

That this is something more than mere caricature (which of course it also is) will become clearer if we recall that contradiction between spontaneity and will power that Tolstoy shared with Stendhal and which became the ideological and moral foundation for his critique of an artificial *mondanité* as well as for a well-nigh ontological attraction to the peasantry. That the episode might also be understood as a more general commentary on the French or Western character (and thereby on the nature of their—revolutionary—collectivity) is not to be excluded either, and will ultimately constitute the philosophical stumbling block of the Second Epilogue: yet the Emperor's egotism and self-centeredness would seem to preclude any easy identification between Napoleon as an individual and whatever collectivity he may be thought to "represent."

It would seem more difficult to argue such a disjunction in the case of Kutuzov, so often taken as the very epitome of the slyness of the Russian peasant and the latter's quintessential stubbornness and suspicion ("it was evident that Kutuzov despised knowledge and cleverness, and knew of something else that would decide the matter—something independent of cleverness and knowledge" [828]). But in order to determine what this "something else" is, we must abandon Kutuzov for the moment and turn to the Second Epilogue.

The language of the Second Epilogue—and the philosophical code into which Tolstoy's thinking is locked—is that of freedom and determinism (or necessity). The problem he poses, however—the dilemma he seeks to resolve—is the political problem of representation as it is raised most dramatically in Rousseau's *Social Contract*; and it will have been clear, I hope, that I take this term "representation" in all its senses and grasp this problem fully as much a narratological problem as a political one. For Rousseau, in other words, the problem of the

[24] Page references to *War and Peace* throughout are to the translation by Louise and Aylmer Maude, New York: Simon and Schuster, 1942, here 685.

One and the Many is that of the possibility of the emergence of a single General Will from the multitude of opinions and factions, ideologies and positions, which constitutes a people or a nation. In our literary context, however, the issue is that of the representation of a collectivity by individual characters; and the discomfort with the obvious recourse to allegorical representation is not unrelated to Rousseau's reluctance to solve his problem by way of mathematical majorities and pluralities: not that he fears for the minority and its fate in an electoral system, but he senses the absence of any available concept for a multiplicity of individuals; there is for Rousseau no available genus of which the individual could possibly be a species, and therefore the very "General Will" itself is the name for an absence, for an impossible concept.

In Tolstoy's version, there clearly exists a bias against the notion of individual freedom, as an illusion that must somehow be eradicated: "consciousness gives expression to the essence of freedom" (1347), and individual freedom can never be disproven... at least in the conscious present of the individual. But here too it is a question of knowledge and of an infinite limit, for "the farther I go back in memory, or what is the same thing the farther I go forward in my judgement, the more doubtful becomes my belief in the freedom of my action" (1342).

The eradication of this illusion will of course at once dispose of the "world-historical individual," whose will no longer has any authority over the course of the world; but it also tends to dissolve the individual character as well, whose decisions (Lukács thought they were best acted out in drama) come to seem less credible and more and more symptomal, in the spirit of modernism or of Freudian psychoanalysis. Meanwhile, in historiography, the waning of the grand historical figures gives rise to the anonymity of cultural collectives of the kind promoted by the *Annales* school, and historical events themselves begin to wane and to disappear. Under such circumstances it would seem difficult to project a historical novel at all, except in the form of sheer anthropological description.

But Tolstoy still holds to his Event, and stubbornly confronts it with his insistence on causes and causality. It may well be so that individual freedom need no longer concern us: "In history what is known to us we call laws of inevitability, what is unknown we call free will. Free will is for history only an expression for the unknown remainder of what we know about the laws of human life" (1348).

But "what is power? What force produces the movement of the

nations?" (1335). It is not an abstract question, but has to do with Kutuzov's strategy in 1812, when he is ordered by the Czar and his general staff (mostly Germans, I might add) to stand and to defend Moscow against the approaching French army. Instead, Kutuzov retreats, abandons the city, and lets it burn, leaving the French nothing but an empty shell for all their victory. This hollow victory is thus Napoleon's defeat, who would have won any official frontal engagement. But does this seemingly suicidal strategy confirm the greatness of Kutuzov as a world-historical individual? Let us return to Prince Andrew's impressions:

> Prince Andrew could not have explained how or why it was, but after that interview with Kutuzov he went back to his regiment reassured as to the general course of affairs and as to the man to whom it had been entrusted. The more he realized the absence of all personal motive in that old man—in whom there seemed to remain only the habit of passions, and in place of an intellect (grouping events and drawing conclusions) only the capacity calmly to contemplate the course of events—the more reassured he was that everything would be as it should. "He will not bring in any plan of his own. He will not devise or undertake anything," thought Prince Andrew, "but he will hear everything, remember everything, and put everything in its place. He will not hinder anything useful nor allow anything harmful. He understands that there is something stronger and more important than his own will—the inevitable course of events, and he can see them and grasp their significance, and seeing that significance can refrain from meddling and renounce his personal wish directed to something else." (831)

It is time to resolve this conundrum: "the something stronger and more important than his own will," the "something else that would decide the matter—something independent of cleverness and knowledge"—that something else is simply the "will" of the people. The Russian people know that Moscow is doomed and that they cannot resist Napoleon; and they also know that they do not want to leave the city to him. The conclusion, then—drawn by the General Will—is to destroy it in the moment of abandoning it. This unconscious collective will is the cause of History. Tolstoy calls the "cause" of an event such as 1812 "a force commensurate with the movement observed" (1321): unsurprisingly, this force will be here identified as the people ("power is the collective will of the people transferred, by expressed or tacit consent, to their chosen rulers" [1313]).

But this philosophical conclusion does not solve our literary one: what is the transfer in question, and how is it to be represented? The "greatness" of Kutuzov is in fact implicit in Prince Andrew's

reflections: it consists in letting history happen, in abandoning his own will, his own self, his own personal assessments, and entrusting his decisions to history itself. This is, to be sure, on one level a well-nigh religious abnegation of self, which can eventually be related to Tolstoy's mysticism on the level of personal ethics and "belief." On the level that interests us here, this position leaves history intact, with all its cataclysmic events, merely stripping it of its actors and decision-makers. As I read it, this is a narratological position, and its seeming "determinism," which does underscore necessity at the heart of its conception of history, is in fact a kind of actantial law: "we see a law by which men, to take associated action, combine in such relations that the more directly they participate in performing the action the less they can command and the more numerous they are, while the less their direct participation in the action itself, the more they command and the fewer of them there are; rising in this way from the lowest ranks to the man at the top, who takes the least direct share in the action and directs his activity chiefly to commanding" (1333).

This is in fact a position which leaves a good deal of play as far as the characters are concerned. Kutuzov's "wisdom" consists in knowing his powerlessness. But there are also comic versions of this knowledge, as witness Bagration's leadership during the battle of Ulm, of which we have already quoted a portion in the previous essay:

> Bagration called to him, and Tushin, raising three fingers to his cap with a bashful and awkward gesture not at all like a military salute but like a priest's benediction, approached the general. Though Tushin's guns had been intended to cannonade the valley, he was firing incendiary balls at the village of Schöngrabern visible just opposite, in front of which large masses of French were advancing.
>
> No one had given Tushin orders where and at what to fire, but after consulting his sergeant major, Zakharchenko, for whom he had great respect, he had decided that it would be a good thing to set fire to the village. "Very good!" said Bagration in reply to the officer's report, and began deliberately to examine the whole battlefield extended before him. The French had advanced nearest on our right. Below the height on which the Kiev regiment was stationed, in the hollow where the rivulet flowed, the soul-stirring rolling and crackling of musketry was heard, and much farther to the right beyond the dragoons, the officer of the suite pointed out to Bagration a French column that was outflanking us. To the left the horizon was bounded by the adjacent wood. Prince Bagration ordered two battalions from the center to be sent to reinforce the right flank. The officer of the suite ventured to remark to the prince that if these battalions went away, the guns would remain without support. Prince Bagration turned to the officer and with his dull eyes looked at him in silence. It seemed to Prince Andrew that the officer's remark was just and that really no answer could be made to it. But at that moment an adjutant galloped up with a message from the commander of the regiment in the hollow and news that immense masses of the French were coming down upon them and that his regiment was in disorder and was retreating upon the Kiev grenadiers. Prince Bagration bowed his head in sign of assent and approval. He rode off at a walk to the right and sent an adjutant to the dragoons with orders to attack the French. But this adjutant returned half an hour later with the news that the commander of the dragoons had already retreated beyond the dip in the ground, as a heavy fire had been opened on him and he was losing men uselessly, and so had hastened to throw some sharpshooters into the wood.
>
> "Very good!" said Bagration.
>
> As he was leaving the battery, firing was heard on the left also, and as it was too far to the left flank for him to have time to go there himself, Prince Bagration sent Zherkov to tell the general in command (the one who had paraded his regiment before Kutuzov at Braunau) that he must retreat as quickly as possible behind the hollow in the rear, as the right flank would probably not be able to withstand the enemy's attack very long. About Tushin and the battalion that had been in support of his battery all was forgotten. Prince Andrew listened attentively to Bagration's colloquies with the commanding officers and the orders he gave them and, to his surprise, found that no orders were really given, but that Prince Bagration tried to make it appear that everything done by necessity, by accident, or by the will of subordinate commanders was done, if not by his direct command, at least in accord with his intentions. Prince Andrew noticed, however, that though what happened was due to chance and was independent of the commander's will, owing to the tact Bagration showed, his presence was very valuable. Officers who approached him with disturbed countenances became calm; soldiers and officers greeted him gaily, grew more cheerful in his presence, and were evidently anxious to display their courage before him. (192–3)

I have dwelt on Tolstoy's theories of history at some length in order to demonstrate that the unique position of *War and Peace* in the history of the historical novel is formally dependent on this idiosyncratic "solution" in which named characters are able to stand for the masses behind them in a non-allegorical way, and in which the narrative can "include" history without utterly abandoning those protagonists without whom it risks sinking back into either a chronicle of the facts or an ethnological account of customs and mentalities. It should be added that Tolstoy's personal relationship to that peasantry of which Lenin saw him as a kind of spokesperson falls into exactly this pattern of passive acceptance and reliance on a force greater than the individual: his story "Metel" paradigmatically shows us a Westernized landlord attempting to reform his peasants and to teach them new and efficient agricultural methods (a drama central to the

eighteenth-century Enlightenment in the West), until, frustrated and exhausted, he gives in and adapts himself to their immemorial ignorant behavior and relationship to the earth (and to Being).

We must now, in conclusion to this section, ask ourselves what kind of historical novel can be possible if Tolstoy's view of reality prevails and if the individual historical protagonists disappear altogether. The answer is, paradoxically, that a narrative possibility still subsists, and retains ideological as well as literary power. It is the tale of the mob, as literature first glimpses it in the counter-revolutionary rhetoric of an Edmund Burke:[25] the revolution seen as a lynching—a vision retained by bourgeois literature, whether in the scientific mode of Freud's appropriation of LeBon in *Group Psychology and the Ego*, or in the far more progressive vision of Zola's *Germinal*. This synecdoche, in which the skirmish stands in for the battle, as Balzac recommended, is a far more forthright and energetic assault on the impossible problem of collective representation than anything on the Left, which is reduced to demonstrations and marches, and whose dilemmas are vividly dramatized by the fact that more actors and extras took part in Eisenstein's filming of *October* than the number of actual participants in the Bolshevik revolution itself.

There is, to be sure, a price to be paid for any narrative solution to the issues grappled with in the *Social Contract*; and it is the oneiric spirit in which collective History and action here for one brief moment make their appearance. I believe that the concept of the uncanny is appropriate for this phantasmagoric state, in which the individual being is briefly raised to another ontological level: that *Aufhebung* which bourgeois and reactionary thinkers saw as a dissolution of individuality and a loss of self in the crowd. For Americans, the story is told most effectively in one of Hawthorne's most successful historical visions, "My Kinsman Major Molineux," in which a youth from the countryside wanders into the midst of a revolutionary event, searching for his Tory kinsman in what it is difficult to distinguish from a carnival.[26] But we may remain with Lukács' classics by citing an

[25] Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790).

[26] The referent peeps through the festivities in the form of a man tarred and feathered and run out of town on a rail, whereby the hero's acquaintance concludes the tale with a flourish magnificent in its irony: "Some few days hence, if you continue to wish it, I will speed you on your journey. Or, if you prefer to remain with us, perhaps, as you are a shrewd youth, you may rise in the world, without the help of your kinsman, Major Molineux." (Hawthorne, *Tales and Sketches*, New York: Library of American, 1982, 87.)

early climax in Walter Scott's finest novel, in which the Edinburgh mob seizes the city and metes justice on a tyrannical lawman, in the process pressing into service the young clergyman who for the moment figures Lukács' average hero and observer:

> "I would it were a dream I could awaken from," said Butler to himself; but, having no means to oppose the violence with which he was threatened, he was compelled to turn round and march in front of the rioters, two men partly supporting and partly holding him.
>
> While this was going on, Butler could not, even if he had been willing, avoid making remarks on the individuals who seemed to lead this singular mob. The torch-light, while it fell on their forms and left him in the shade, gave him an opportunity to do so without their observing him. Several of those who appeared most active were dressed in sailors' jackets, trowsers, and sea-caps; others in large loose-bodied great-coats, and slouched hats; and there were several, who, judging from their dress, should have been called women, whose rough deep voices, uncommon size, and masculine deportment and mode of walking, forbade their being so interpreted. They moved as if by some well-concerted plan of arrangement. They had signals by which they knew, and nick-names by which they distinguished each other. Butler remarked, that the name of Wildfire was used among them, to which one stout Amazon seemed to reply.[27]

Transvestism is to be sure itself one of the prime characteristics of carnival, on the Bakhtinian or any other point of view, expressing the "world turned upside down" of this moment, which is here and in Bakhtin himself the figure for the revolutionary Event as such. (Le Roy Ladurie's *Carnival in Romans* offers a striking narrative of the same moment in an anthropological mode). At any rate, the authorities in London are under no illusions as to the hermeneutic significance of this moment of disorder in Scotland; and as for Bakhtin, I have suggested that his theory is weakened by its insertion into a cyclical temporality which domesticates and "anthropologizes" it. He himself clearly intended his account of a moment of Renaissance licentiousness and liberation to stand for the revolutionary culture of the Soviet 1920s, compressed between the Czarist old regime (in his narrative, the middle ages) and the repressive new order of Stalinism (here figured as the Counter-Reformation). Bakhtin's is then in effect yet another historical novel;[28] and the oneiric carnival it celebrates is

[27] Walter Scott, *The Heart of Midlothian*, London: Penguin, 1994, 59–60.

[28] Mikhail Bakhtin, *Rabelais and his World*, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1984, 72: "The disintegration of the feudal and theocratic order of the Middle Ages

the last possible representation of the Event of a multitude without named actors.

3.

The next logical and formal possibility will then be that of names without events, and indeed I believe this reduction of the world-historical individuals to little more than their names is what characterizes one of the two distinctive forms of the historical novel today. Names are indeed the remnants of historical "prior knowledge," the detritus of the schoolbooks, nouns from the General Intellect stagnating in the collective unconscious and attempting organically to reconnect amoeba-like in the Internet. As we shall see, such historical names, bloated with biography, tend towards an autonomy of their own as the history of which they were once a part becomes spongy. But it is the mode of this autonomization which is curious and even paradoxical.

For it may be said to begin precisely in that process of critical reexamination, of historical intervention into the stereotypes of the past, of fresh historiographic revision, which we have seen at work in an inconspicuous way in Mantel's Robespierre. Nowadays, it is not so much an ideological belief in the past as multiple narratives—in all its versions as so many different ways "the story is told"—as it is the sheer accumulation of all those versions in what has complacently come to be called the Archive ("after Foucault"). It is sheer multiplicity itself which guarantees that none of these narratives can or should be taken at face value—a serious blow to the serious historian. But even in a less saturated period there were several ways in which the name could survive the fact and even the story.

The most traditional was of course the hero-worshipping or hagiographic mode stoutly and anachronistically championed by Carlyle and continuing to draw its strength from the inherited stereotypes, with "interesting" minor variations, so that John Ford's *Young Mr.*

also contributed to the fusion of the official and nonofficial. The culture of folk humor that had been shaped during many centuries and that had defended the people's creativity in nonofficial forms, in verbal expression or spectacle, could now rise to the high level of literature and ideology and fertilize it. Later, in times of absolute monarchy and the formation of a new official order, folk humor descended to the lower level of the genre hierarchy. There it settled and broke away from its popular roots, becoming petty, narrow, and degenerate."

Lincoln becomes a detective, Gore Vidal's a racist, and a contemporary version, modishly enough, becomes a vampire-killer. But there is more often the mode of caricature, such as Melville's version of Benjamin Franklin in *Redburn*, in which the existence of the historical personage is reconfirmed by his all-too-human feet of clay. In both modes, interrogation, a hermeneutic curiosity about the past, is steadily maintained and pursued; and perhaps it is a matter of autoreferentiality when, as in his unexpected appearance at the end of *Lotte in Weimar*, Thomas Mann's Goethe proves to be an enigma, glacially persisting in his undecideability, which turns out to be the undecideability of the past as such.

Finally, it is precisely this undecideability which ends up detaching the name from its "referent." The most conspicuous modernist view of the past has posited a longing to recapture or recreate it. Proust generally serves as the canonical demonstration of this will to make the past live again, but Joyce's elaborate literary reconstruction of 1904 Dublin, Thomas Mann's endless musings on time, moments in Pound and Eliot, political nostalgia in Yeats, all among much else document this strange vocation of the modernists, which does not seem to have any real equivalent, either among the so-called realists of the nineteenth century novel, or among ourselves. But if you had a great deal of money, and no particular literary gifts as such, you might imagine going about it in a different way. Here, for example, is Dos Passos's evocation of the old age of Henry Ford in *The Big Money* (the last volume of the *USA* trilogy):

> Henry Ford as an old man
> is a passionate antiquarian
> (lives besieged on his father's farm embedded in an estate of thousands of
> millionaire acres, protected by an army of servicemen, secretaries, secret agents,
> dicks under orders of an English exprizefighter,
> always afraid of the feet in broken shoes on the roads, afraid the gangs will
> kidnap his grandchildren,
> that a crank will shoot him,
> that Change and the idle hands out of work will break through the gates and the
> high fences;
> protected by a private army against
> the new America of starved children and hollow bellies and cracked shoes
> stamping on souplines,
> that has swallowed up the old thrifty farmlands
> of Wayne County, Michigan,
> as if they had never been).

Henry Ford as an old man
is a passionate antiquarian.
He rebuilt his father's farmhouse and put it back exactly in the state he remembered it in as a boy. He built a village of museums for buggies, sleighs, coaches, old plows, waterwheels, obsolete models of motorcars. He scoured the country for fiddlers to play oldfashioned squaredances.
Even old taverns he bought and put back into their original shape, as well as Thomas Edison's early laboratories.
When he bought the Wayside Inn near Sudbury, Massachusetts, he had the new highway where the newmodel cars roared and slithered and hissed oilily past (*the new noise of the automobile*)
moved away from the door,
put back the old bad road,
so that everything might be
the way it used to be,
in the days of horses and buggies.[29]

This is less an interpretation of Ford (about whom a modern biographer—the director of the Henry Ford museum itself—has implausibly asserted that he "built this place [Greenfield Village] out of guilt")[30] than it is an imputation to him of Dos Passos's own aesthetic, as it wavers uneasily between modernism and a postmodernism to come. But the emphasis on accuracy, authenticity and "complete restoration" in Ford's project may turn out to be less a Proustian recovery of the past than a whole new construction, as in this account by a contemporary witness, of Ford's transfer of Edison's laboratory in Menlo Park to the new site in Michigan:

> Before he moved the laboratory here, he went out to New Jersey—the land where the building was originally—and dug up tons of dirt, just tons of it. Then he had it all earthed out here and dumped it all over this site before they stuck the building down on top of it. That was his idea of complete restoration. This place had been built on New Jersey soil, so it should be restored on New Jersey soil. Stuff like that drove the experts crazy.[31]

The element of hero-worshipping, so central to Ford's later personality, is here allied to something closer to time-travel, the not necessarily so materialist urge to recreate a physical site in which one could oneself

[29] John Dos Passos, *The Big Money*, New York: New American Library, 1960, 76–77.
[30] David Lowenthal, *The Past is a Foreign Country*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999, 328.
[31] Ibid., 288.

stroll about. It is this urge which was so memorably recaptured in Philip K. Dick's *Now Wait for Last Year*, where we confront a three-hundred-year-old industrialist and millionaire—his body regenerated through countless organ transplants over the years while his mind is arguably somewhat more senescent—who shows many of the features of Henry Ford's strange passion.

Virgil Ackermann is, for example, a passionate collector of authentic memorabilia, items increasingly rare in this bleak future world. When his staff feel the need to underscore their devotion, for example, they find nothing quite so suitable as to acquire, at great expense, from the businesses who specialize in such rarities, a green Lucky Strike cigarette package wrapper certified as having been produced in the pre-World-War-II period. He receives these metonymic objects with real delight, but it should not be thought that he simply accumulates them in a random way. Rather, he owns a complete lunar estate or encampment, significantly named Wash-35, which is to say a reconstruction of Washington, D.C. in the year 1935, or at the time of the millionaire's boyhood. Here, as with Ford's boyhood farmhouse, the whole neighborhood has been lovingly rebuilt just as it was, including robot or android simulacra of familiar childhood figures:

> The emphases of Wash-35, a five-story brick apartment building where Virgil had lived as a boy, contained a truly modern apartment of their year 2055 with every detail of convenience which Virgil could obtain during these war years. Several blocks away lay Connecticut Avenue, and, along it, stores which Virgil remembered. Here was Gammage's a shop at which Virgil had bought Tip Top comics and penny candy. Next to it Eric made out the familiar shape of People's Drugstore; the old man during his childhood had bought a cigarette lighter here once and chemicals for his Gilbert Number Five glass blowing and chemistry set.
>
> "What's the Uptown Theatre showing this week?" Harv Ackerman murmured as their ship coasted along Connecticut Avenue so that Virgil could review these treasured sights. He peered.
>
> It was Jean Harlow in *Hell's Angels*, which all of them had seem at least twice. Harv groaned.[32]

But it is worth revisiting this historical figure (or name) one last time, in a fully postmodern guise where Ford—no longer a mere insert as in Dos Passos—reappears as a minor character, whose typically American slyness and practicality (we have just been treated to a presentation of the innovation of the assembly line) finds itself

[32] Philip K. Dick, *Now Wait for Last Year*, New York: DAW, 1966, 27.

unexpectedly conjoined to an (equally typical?) weakness for the occult and for mysticism. The scene takes place during a visit of the inventor to J. P. Morgan:

> When he had satisfied himself that he understood, he nodded his head solemnly and replied as follows: If I understand you right, Mr. Morgan, you are talking about reincarnation. Well, let me tell you about that. As a youth I was faced with an awful crisis in my mental life when it came over me that I had no call to know what I knew. I had grit, all right, but I was an ordinary country boy who had suffered his McGuffey like the rest of them. Yet I knew how everything worked. I could look at something and tell you how it worked and probably show you how to make it work better. But I was no intellectual, you see, and I had no patience with the two-dollar words.
>
> Morgan listened. He felt that he mustn't move.
>
> Well then, Ford continued, I happened to pick up a little book. It was called *An Eastern Fakir's Eternal Wisdom*, published by the Franklin Novelty Company of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. And in this book, which cost me just twenty-five cents, I found everything I needed to set my mind at rest. Reincarnation is the only belief I hold, Mr. Morgan. I explain my genius this way—some of us have just lived more times than others. So you see, what you have spent on scholars and traveled around the world to find, I already knew. And I'll tell you something, in thanks for the eats, I'm going to lend that book to you. Why, you don't have to fuss with all these Latiny things, he said waving his arm, you don't have to pick the garbage pails of Europe and build steamboats to sail the Nile just to find out something that you can get in the mail order for two bits![33]

Reincarnation does seem to be a better technical characterization for the postmodern relationship to historical names than any modernist "*recherche du temps perdu*," and this not only for the obvious constructivist reasons and the commitment to a present which forecludes the indirections of memory, remembrance or mere commemoration. We must also here reinscribe the fortunes and the aftereffects of contemporary semiotic philosophies, which displace that dualism of words and things, signs and referents, that continue to motivate the aesthetics of the modern. But the latter's commitment to mimesis must not be misunderstood as a belief that the representation can somehow fully reproduce its original. Rather, the point is to demonstrate its failure, its structural incapacity to represent reality, to designate its grandiose project of doing so as "mere" art and artifice, in an autoreferentiality of the aesthetic as such and its overweening autonomy.

[33] E.R. Doctorow, *Ragtime*, New York: Random House, 1975, pp. 173–4.

In the postmodern, where the original no longer exists and everything is an image, there can no longer be any question either of the accuracy or truth of representation, or of any aesthetic of mimesis either. Deleuze's "*puissance du faux*"[34] is a misnomer to the degree that, where the true is ontologically absent, there can be nothing false or fictive either: such concepts no longer apply to a world of simulacra, where only the names—Lacan's "*points de capiton*," Kripke's "rigid designators"—remain, like time capsules deposited by aliens who have no history or chronology in our sense in the first place.

Significantly, Doctorow's "portrait" of Ford is accompanied by a far more elaborate "fictional" character to whom he attributes the invention of the movie camera and indeed of motion pictures as such. Ford's contribution—the model-T whose theft sparks the main plot, the stirring pastiche of Kleist's *Michael Kohlhaas*—is thus subtly displaced by this non-narrative of the inventor and his daughter, who take the trolley to the end of the line and then walk to the beginning of the trolley of the adjacent township, thereby tracing a network of the imaginary that is ultimately more durable than Ford's highways, which are after all not replicated in his own museum, remaining imaginary, very much in Malraux's sense.

This is also a move from the narrative to the non-narrative. Dos Passos's original and fundamental isolation of the great historical name and its insertion by fiat into a world of imaginary characters is to that degree unable to generate a new narrative mode for the historical novel, but at best a kind of lateral return of the repressed, as an interesting contemporary German practice of the form suggests. *Die Vermessung der Welt* (*Measuring the World*) offers a lively cartoon version of the travels of Alexander von Humboldt intercalated with episodes from the life of the great mathematician (and astronomer) Christian Gauss.

The passage I want to quote evokes a perilous ascension of mount Chimborazo, a volcano now situated in Ecuador:

> With groping steps they made their way alongside the cliff. Bonpland [Humboldt's travelling companion] remarked that he actually consisted of three people: one who moved, one who observed the Bonpland in motion, and one who tirelessly accompanied them with a commentary in a language unknown to anyone. As a test he hit himself on the ear. That helped for a moment or two, and for those moments he thought more clearly. But that did not change the fact that earth

[34] Gilles Deleuze, *Cinéma II*, Paris: Minuit, 1985, chapter 6.

now lay where the sky ought to be and vice versa, or in other words that they were actually descending upside down.[35]

Humboldt himself is accompanied, incidentally, not by doubles or triples, but by the vision of a homeless dog he has abandoned. Kehlmann's own intent is not without interest for us: "to tell the past anew," as he puts it, "and to deviate from the official version into the realm of invented truth." In fact, part of Kehlmann's invention has consisted in leaving something out: for the original expedition actually included a third person, a guide, whom the novelist has omitted, supplying instead the physical sickness, distress, hallucinations, which are amply recorded in the literature of mountain climbing but which Humboldt's own account itself omits. "In the sovereign cool tone of Humboldt's report there thus lies no less fiction than in the confused and staggering episode I have made it into," concludes Kehlmann, in his interesting essay "Wo ist Carlos Montúfar?" (the name of the real life guide he has omitted from his own narrative).[36] The hallucinated third person is also, however, one of the characters in virtually the most canonical classic of modernism itself:

> Who is the third who walks always beside you?
> When I count, there are only you and I together
> But when I look ahead up the white road
> There is always another one walking beside you
> Gliding wrapt in a brown mantle, hooded
> I do not know whether a man or a woman
> – But who is that on the other side of you?

These verses, from the climax of *The Waste Land*, have often been taken to have a religious meaning (nor are they without any connection with Philip K. Dick's "religion" of Mercerism in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*); but I mean to think of them now in another way. Here is Eliot's footnote to this passage: "The following lines were stimulated by the account of one of the Antarctic expeditions (I forget which but I think one of Shackleton's); it was related that the party of explorers, at the extremity of their strength, had the constant delusion that there was one more member than could actually be counted."[37] And here is the actual account by one of the three

[35] Daniel Kehlmann, *Die Vermessung der Welt*, Hamburg: Rowohlt 2005, 175.
[36] Daniel Kehlmann, *Wo ist Carlos Montúfar?*, Hamburg: Rowohlt, 2005, 12.
[37] T. S. Eliot, *The Waste Land*, note 360.

survivors of the Endurance crew, the navigator Frank Worsley: "Sir Ernest and I, comparing notes, found that we each had a strange feeling there had been a fourth in our party and Crean [the third survivor] afterwards confessed the same thing."[38] To be sure, from the religious standpoint the change in number is significant. From ours, however, it is the multiplication of characters or participants which is the point of interest.[39]

[38] Frank Worsley, *Endurance*, New York: Norton, 2000 [1931].
[39] It is worth comparing this experience with the narrative of another historical novel, *Götz and Meyer* (trans. Ellen Elias-Bursac, New York: Harcourt, 2004), a kind of pre-Holocaust and magic-realist or "postmodern" novel about two SS truck-drivers who are instrumental in the experiments in gassing people in busses before the actual construction of the gas chambers as such. The narrator (a teacher) is very much a character in this novel, or rather the novel explicitly represents his attempt to imagine these two drivers of the lethal truck in which his own family was murdered. The question is then, not whether the facts of the narrative are true or false, but whether the imagining itself really happened; that is to say, is the experience of this imagining to be attributed to the biographical novelist called David Albahari (leaving out of it the question of whether his own family was thus involved), or is one not to assume that the whole thing is a novelist's idea for a new and interesting kind of Holocaust novel no one had quite written in this way before? (We thereby also omit the final suicide of the narrator himself.) It is at any rate one of the most successful works in that genre of the novel about the wilting of the novel as it has evolved since *Tristram Shandy*, with the qualification that the Holocaust material (itself a genre) serves to mask or cancel the frivolity of the postmodern play of genres as such. At any rate, the passage that will now concern us tells the story of the appearance of yet a third (or fourth) unwanted and fictional character within his narrative: "I would rather tilt at windmills, even the old and decrepit kind, the way they are now, Götz and Meyer, if they are alive. I never met them, I can only imagine them. I'm back where I began. This is what my life has turned into: stumbling, looking back, starting anew. One of those three lives I was living in parallel, maybe even a fourth. The rest continued to follow me, unchanged, and I'd wake up like Götz, or Meyer, eager to work, and go to sleep like a thirteen-year-old boy preparing for his bar mitzvah and repeating words in a language that made his throat ache. None of my relatives in the camp could be described as a thirteen-year-old boy, nor do I know where he came from, nor which life he belongs to. Götz and Meyer are also unable to help me. If we had remembered all those faces, they say, we'd remember nothing else. The boy kept popping up, and on one occasion, instead of my own hands, I saw his, clear as day. He was clutching a mug of milk and he was thirsty. He was in me that day, when, in a voice squeaky with excitement, I proposed to my students that we spend our next class in a hands-on demonstration. Although beside themselves at the thought that they wouldn't have to be in school, they wanted to know what was going to happen. The boy had, in the meanwhile, faded, leaving me to respond. It was going to be about the difference between the tangible world and art, I explained, but also about the similarity between an instant of reality and a figment of the imagination.

We might have added that, according to another character (the impresario-photographer Daguerre, yet another historical name included here), Humboldt's "long-awaited travel report disappointed the public: hundreds of pages of measurements and statistics, scarcely anything personal, practically no adventures."[40] But Kehlmann's historical novel can scarcely be said to constitute an attempt to substitute the narrative of those missing adventures (which one can imagine a traditional historical novel doing in abundance). Rather, setting forth from the surviving names, it ends up generating another anthropomorphic phantom of an unnamed third, in an account hallucinogenic rather than hallucinatory. This is not the delirium of collectivity we witnessed in the previous section, but rather simply the production of an additional character alongside the names he began with. The path of the historical names is anthropomorphic, it leads to multiplication rather than multiplicity. It remains to be seen whether a different path to the renewal of the historical novel in our time is still available.

4.

We have followed the vicissitudes of the great as they shrink from their elaborate costume settings and adventures into the empty shell of mere names and their most unlikely combinations. It remains to complete this diagnosis of the contemporary transformations of our historicity, pathological or not, with a brief look at their opposite number, namely the collectivity and its imaginary metamorphoses.

I was pretty busy for a few days. I had to find a school bus, collect money from the students, work out the route, get my thoughts together" (126–7). This shadowy third figure might well be theorized as the return in exteriority of the new "subjective" third person identified in Chapter VIII of Part One, above.

[40] Kehlmann, *Vermessung*, 239. The generic term "postmodern novel" already seems to be current for "textual" or severely "reflexive" books of the type of *House of Leaves*, with more traditional historical-novelistic precursors in *The French Lieutenant's Woman* or *Possession*. Related texts, such as Cesar Aira's *An Episode in the Life of a Landscape Painter*, New York: New Directions, 2000 (a reference I owe to Emilio Sauri), or Doctorow, or those of writers like Ken Kalfuss, suggest the need for a new generic category for narratives organized, not around the feel of a period, but rather around historical proper names which circulate through what is often sheer fictional play, of a type quite distinct from the period simulacra of nostalgia film.

In that tug of war between chronology and structure, diachrony and synchrony, history and sociology or anthropology, to which we have already referred, it is clearly the latter that wins out on this side of the tension. A history without names, whether it is the description of a mode of production or an ethnological report, whether it follows the various codes and inscriptions of Deleuze and Guattari in "*sauvages, barbares, civilisés*" (Morgan's classification) or the detailed graphs of Lévi-Strauss's villages (or Bourdieu's in "La maison Kabyle"), will inevitably tend towards a tableau without events; nor is it terribly different for our purposes of classification from those historicisms of the late nineteenth century which found their delectation in the exoticisms of this or that period of the cultural past (always different, alien, and thereby virtually by definition exotic in the first place). And to be sure, narration and the event can always be pressed into service as a pretext for the panorama of otherness, the time travel of historical tourism.

Oddly enough, insofar as the temporal thinkers seem to agree that no historicity can function properly without a dimension of futurity, however imaginary, it is we ourselves who normally stand in for the place of the future, as we peer into the various pasts offered by novels claiming to be historical. And we remember our peculiar position occasionally by way of our irritation with too conspicuous modernization in the feelings or sayings of these allegedly long-dead figures, and the anachronism of their unwanted contemporaneity.

Still, the problem of what to do with the future in the historical novel is scarcely an unrewarding one, as witness the question of endings, and their relationship to the reader's prior knowledge. As for the history of the future itself, unless it is understood to be a literary genre (Science Fiction), we often tend to abandon it to prophets and Cassandras, if not to the writers of best-sellers on the subject, without remembering that every present of time in which we move includes its own dimension of futurity, of fears and expectations, which (realized or not) at once accompany that present into the past along with it, as what Sartre called "dead futures." Of those, no doubt, one could write a history, or at least a historical novel. (Francis Spufford's *Red Plenty*, for example, is one such registration of a future history we do not find in the history books.)[41]

[41] Francis Spufford, *Red Plenty*, London: Greywolf, 2012. See also my review in *New Left Review* 75 (May–June 2012).

I suspect that in these areas it is the notion of the fictional that creates the greatest mental confusion: for the historical novel was traditionally a contract whereby we agreed to tolerate a certain number of fictional characters and actions within a framework equally agreed to be factual. And no doubt we are willing to tolerate fictional characters in an imaginary future as well, since it is itself a fiction which will eventually be factual, no matter what we do about it.

But who would the world-historical individuals of such a future be, and are not the great names of such a future inevitable projections of our own present and past, as with the Caesar who will in a few years from now found the hegemony of the apes over our own species? Yet the invention of Science Fiction was assuredly a modification of our historicity to which a genuine historical cause can be assigned with some precision: the emergence of imperialism on a world scale in the Berlin Conference of 1885. (Wells' *War of the Worlds* specifically evokes the extermination of the Tasmanians as his inspiration.) The only other genre which can be thus clinically interrogated as an analogous symptom of a structural modification of history and our consciousness of it is, of course, the historical novel, whose relations with the French Revolution are complex and demonstrable. (Those who, on the contrary, take Mary Shelley's 1811 *Frankenstein* as the true emergence of modern Science Fiction can then adopt this argument as well.)

In what follows I will want to claim, however outrageously, that the historical novel of the future (which is to say of our own present) will necessarily be Science-Fictional inasmuch as it will have to include questions about the fate of our social system, which has become a second nature. To read the present as history, as so many have urged us to do, will mean adopting a Science-Fictional perspective of some kind, and we are fortunate to have at least one recent novel which, against all expectations, gives us an idea of what that might look like.

Before examining it, however, I will take the liberty of introducing a filmic exhibit, less as a text than as a model and a kind of thought experiment. To be sure, film has always been an avid accomplice of the historical novel, from costume dramas to special effects, from local color to the unexpected resurrection of the Titanic. In particular, what I have called "nostalgia films" very much belong in our current category of the milieu without the character, of a historicist reconstruction in which not only the world-historical figures but even the everyday street life have vanished, transformed into a caricatural

realization and simulacrum of that "world of objects" Hegel and Lukács associated with epic, a world dated by costume and fashion, haircuts and coiffures, hit songs, popular music, the yearly make of the automobile and the occasional distinctive building style, which (all of them twentieth century) mark our visual experience as the neo-epic of a named period, whether the '20s or the '50s: for finally it is periodization and its styles which, as we shall see, are central to this new version of the form. The present as history nowadays requires us to turn it into just such a named period, and to endow it with a period style, on which we look back.

The film I wish to take as a point of departure here is however not a nostalgia film in the technical or generic sense, and I only need it to help me make a few points which will be useful later on. As so often in SF (in *Necromancer*, for example) the plot is borrowed from another genre, in this case the heist or caper film, even though it is here less a question of stealing a priceless object than of breaking and entering the mind of another character, in order to modify a crucial decision. But what is crucial here, and original in Christopher Nolan's film *Inception* (2010), is that its working premise is neither magical nor subjective. Indeed, as with much of modern philosophy, it evades the subject/object division altogether, by way of a new distribution of elements: the team is able, collectively, to enter the "mind" of the target by modifying it objectively in order to secure another outcome and a different decision. But the "real" cast of characters of the targeted individual's mind and environment persist in being and remain in place; and the plot is animated by their sense of an intrusion and a violation by the team of thieves and by the collective hostility they are able to marshall in opposition—a device which advances the action but is of no further interest to us here. What is significant is that this new system advances cinema itself to the degree to which it absolutely repudiates the latter's older conventions of subjectivity. These are neither dream-sequences of the traditional kind, nor hallucinations, nor even flash-backs. (It is ironic that the film DiCaprio made immediately before this one, Scorsese's *Shutter Island*, was a pastiche of all these old subjective illusions, thereby risking a fatal misunderstanding on the part of the public of *Inception* and leading it to misconstrue its true originality.) At best, today, the flashback is underscored by a shift from color (the present) to black-and-white or sepia (the past); but most often by a radical shift in style, so that a memory of the '30s, for example, is staged in the manner of '30s

films. (I believe it was Ingmar Bergman who pioneered this device in the magnificent silent-movie sequence of *Sawdust and Tinsel* [1953].) The use of style itself as an index or a connotation (in Barthes' early sense) is important, and we will come back to it later.

But the contemporaneity of *Inception* (its postmodernity rather than its postmodernism) is to be found in this aesthetic of an absolute present, where, as Adorno warned about late capitalism, all negativity has been tendentially reduced and extirpated—and this not only in his sense of the distances still maintained by critique and "critical theory," but even in the temporal sense of the gaps left by the past and the mirages fitfully generated by the future: an absolute reduction to the present (what Adorno called "nominalism") and a mesmerization by the empirically and sensorially existent. Film always moved towards this absolute plenitude of a present of sight and sound: *Inception* has "motivated the device" (to use Shklovsky's expression for the rationalization of an aesthetic necessity) and has turned what was a historic tendency into a one-time structural premise. To which we may also add two more features: the modification of architecture around stable characters is very consistent with the structural alternatives just outlined for the temporary historical novel itself; and the fact that the newly invented environment or constructed world is a Potemkin-like projection which only exists in the general and not in the detail strongly confirms its relationship to stereotypes (and images) rather than to an older mimetic realism.

Now we can draw the lessons we need from *Inception*: the various situations it needs to construct around its targeted characters are also so many worlds which need to be coordinated in some way. The Golden Age of SF did this by means of that narrative part of speech I will call the doorway: the portal whereby a bemused character of van Vogt stepped from her darkened rundown North American bedroom into an exotic landscape (bright with sun, tropical in its vegetation).[42]

To be sure, all narrative requires such syntactical conjunction: "the art of transitions," as Wagner called it, and as Flaubert practiced it. The historians conventionally called upon that fictional category named Causality to do this work for them and to suture their disparate moments, the heterogeneity of their times and places. But causality has fallen into a neglect justified by philosophical skepticism and just that nominalism diagnosed by Adorno; and one cannot say that its

[42] See my *Archaeologies of the Future*, London: Verso, 2005, chapter 6.

much-maligned "linear history" has been any better served by loops and cyclical time, simultaneities and alternate worlds, repetitions and eternal returns, the demon of analogy, and the various other conceits remaining at the bottom of the tool-kit of Western grand narratives.

What is not wrong about these attempts, however, is that they confirm the implication—in Deleuze's formulations of "the image of thought," for example[43]—that what is needed is not so much a new theory or system, as precisely a new image of time, a one-time ad-hoc invention which can be discarded after productive use: "shapes of time," to use George Kubler's useful formula,[44] against which Lyotardian incredulity is quite unnecessary, since no one really believes in them in the first place. Still, here are a few:

> It is difficult to tabulate dates from different calendars, for example, speculative Biblical dates against confirmed Roman dates. This leads drafters of time-lines to experiment with almost every imaginable graphic design. A survey of the history of time-lines reveals time-"lines" pictured as time-trees, time-rivers, concentric time-wheels, kaballistic time-bodies, frenzied gothic lines, time-mazes, time-atlases, time-hydraulics, time-cartoons, time-palaces, Doomsday docks and astrological convergence-charts, palm-lines readied for chronological palm-reading, immense fold-out "synchronologies," and time-line graphics that look more like piles of hair or over-wired computer chips.[45]

The shape *Inception* provides us with is that of its massive central elevator, which rises and falls to the levels of its various worlds, its portals opening on past or future indifferently, and on the weathers of the globe's named spaces and the interiors—modern or antique, glass or dark wood—of its innumerable yet distinct and disjoined situations.

The historical novel today must be seen as an immense elevator that moves us up and down in time, its sickening lifts and dips corresponding to the euphoric or dystopian mood in which we wait for the doors to open. For historicity today—an acute consciousness of what Heidegger would call the historicality of our historical situations—demands a temporal span far exceeding the biological limits of the individual human organism: so that the life of a single character—world-historical or not—can scarcely accommodate it;

[43] Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *Qu'est-ce que la philosophie?*, Paris: Éditions de Minuit, 1991, 39.

[44] George Kubler, *The Shape of Time*, New Haven: Yale, 1962.

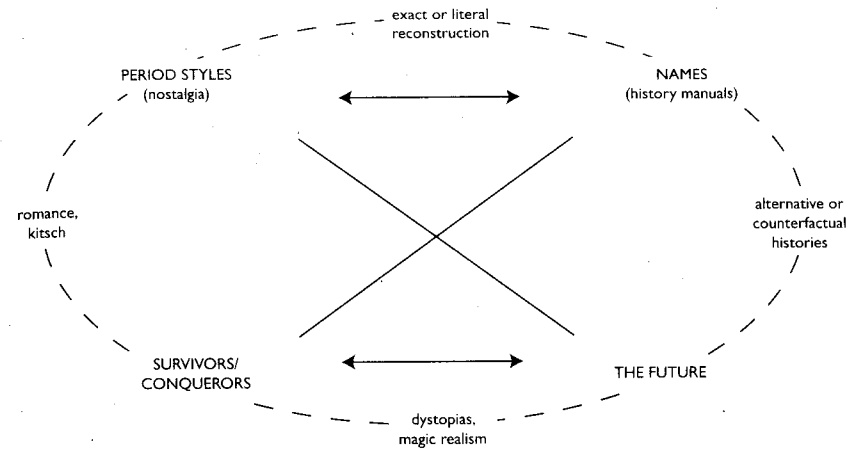
[45] Jay Lampert, *Simultaneity and Delay*, London: Continuum, 2012, 3.

nor even the meager variety of our own chronological experiences of a limited national time and place.

The traditional historians placidly enumerated their chronicles with little enough existential anxiety, when they did not mark their materials as legendary hearsay or myths swimming up from the distant past. (Indeed, they rarely possessed a conception of such "distance" in the past, all their stories told "as if" of yesterday.) Novelists have not had it much easier: Kim Stanley Robinson's immense counterfactual epic of an alternate world[46] has recourse to reincarnation in order to control his temporal open spaces and to preserve the identity of his ambassadors to History.

Inception's problem in this respect is somewhat different: it must ward off those illusions and categories of a bad subjectivity we have already denounced, and prevent characters and audience alike from falling into the trance of "virtual dream" or a P. K. Dick-inspired schizophrenic hallucination. The trick will be turned by way of a small and insignificant object, about which much might be said philosophically: it is the small and quite undistinguished "jack" (as in the game of jacks) which DiCaprio carries in his pocket and which assures the passage of identity from one world to another. Neither fetish nor token, with neither use nor exchange value, by definition a "lost object" (as beneath a sofa cushion) which must not be lost at all costs, the skeleton of an object, its abstraction, a cube reduced to a few transversal bars so denuded you can scarcely tell their color—the little jack is the Lacanian "quilting point" or "upholstery nail" that holds all this together; and History also needs just such a material leitmotif, which might be a birthmark, a tell-tale word, or any other inconspicuous material sign whose presence is enough to reassure us that history has a meaning after all. Or such is the constructional conceit of *Cloud Atlas*, that unique contemporary "historical novel" with which we will conclude this essay.

[46] Kim Stanley Robinson, *The Years of Rice and Salt*, New York: Bantam, 2002. The lifetime allotted to the historical observer is obviously a crucial problem for the representation of long-term change, inasmuch as our biological existence does not correspond to the temporal rhythms of socio-economic history. Woolf's *Orlando* solves it one way, Luther Blissett's *Q* another (mainly by distracting you from calculating the protagonist's real age; its authors are the Italian collective now known as Wu Ming, Chinese for "anonymous.") Meanwhile there are still the continuities of the family novel still available in those parts of the world where remnants of the clan system still persist, but no longer in the "West."



This is an elevator of a novel that stops briefly at a number of disparate floors on its way to the far future; and their relation to each other in space and time is preponderantly centered on the Pacific Rim—with some Scottish and Belgian exceptions—and connected in the unmistakable zigzags by which a hacker conceals the source of his transmission, or the random order on a bookshelf of a set of travel guides and memoirs jumbled in their dates and places in time. This unsystematic stacking of unfinished manuscripts which might have remained buried in various drawers stimulates that unconscious part of the dream work Freud called *Überdeterminierung* (a word since hijacked for other theoretical, but paradoxically not unhistoriographic, purposes) in which, in its function as "secondary elaboration" (an earlier translation I prefer), it impels us to invent as many connections and cross-references as we can think of in an ongoing process. Probably all of modernism arouses this not necessarily admirable drive we often assimilate to Interpretation as such; but here, at least, we can wonder whether the interest lies in the content of such symbolic themes and interconnections or in the ontological foregrounding of the process itself.

At any rate, a composition planned by the young composer-protagonist of one of the earlier segments lays out the plan of his Cloud Atlas Sextet in a fairly inescapable hint:

> overlapping soloists: piano, clarinet, cello, flute, oboe and violin, each in its own language of key, scale and color. In the first set, each solo is interrupted by its successor: in the second, each interruption is reconstituted, in order.

> Revolutionary or gimmicky? Shan't know until it's finished, and by then it'll be too late.[47]

The sextet, and thus by extension and magnification the novel itself, both practice what may be called an aesthetic of singularity, in which what is constructed is not meant to be the elaboration of a style or the practice of a genre (even a newly hinted one), but rather the experimental projection of a single one-time conceit, unimitable and without a legacy or any intention of founding a tradition formal or otherwise: not a new style, but the assemblage of various styles, as we shall see.

So we begin with 1) a narrative of the sea and of Pacific colonization, whose hero is a lawyer traveling halfway around the world to execute a contract—shades of Jonathan Harker!—in a Melvillian world which follows the footsteps of Captain Cook, reminiscent of *Mason and Dixon*, until we realize that the confusion it generates between an eighteenth-century journal or daybook and the nineteenth-century reality of its squalid colonies is simply the continuity of a whole world to which the steamship will in a year or two put an end; 2) a fin-de-siècle or *symboliste* drama in which the fictionalized life of the young composer who helped the semi-paralyzed Delius write his final works is expressed in cynical letters which combine the autonomy of art and a semi-incestuous eroticism à la Thomas Mann; 3) a corporate thriller about a young investigative reporter exposing the ecological predations concealed behind government contracts in a California setting; 4) a first-person and very British gossip-columnist memoir of an impecunious and aging upper-class publisher whose family has confined him ito an old-person's home; 5) a Science-Fictional far-future dystopia about the repression of androids in one of those North-Korean dictatorial fantasies which have suddenly become so popular (see also *The Orphan Father's Son*) as though in an informational universe this last hermetically sealed non-nation-state were the final place in which our bleaker imaginations of the future could still run riot, although furnished with rudimentary SF technology and pajamas à la Star Trek; 6) a post-Holocaust reversion to simple village life on a Hawaii menaced by more advanced and bloodthirsty neighboring tribes and told in the manner of *Huckleberry Finn*, intersecting with a small surviving minority of

[47] David Mitchell, *Cloud Atlas*, New York: Random House, 2004, 445. Page numbers in text refer to this edition.

scientifically trained and knowledgeable experts from a future now past, much as the inhabitants of Camelot confront the Connecticut Yankee.

A variety of genres surely, about which it is hard to say whether any one of them brought to true novelistic completion would be finally worth reading in its own right. The combination certainly incites us to wonder whether it is a random sample, or whether taken together these episodes somehow form a coherent picture of the stereotypes which govern our current view of history, past, present and future, or even project some ideal caricature of that Pacific Rim culture to which David Mitchell (himself an Englishman) seems personally attached. If so, then the selection, whose arbitrariness somehow does not seem arbitrary in the reading of it, has that legitimacy of authentic dead pasts and dead futures, the legitimacy of our own collective Imaginary, as I have suggested, however spurious its details might be. But it is not clear to me that the combination—Bruges, the South Seas, nuclear power plants on the San Andreas Fault, British gangsters and skinheads, let alone North Korean dystopias and neolithic Hawaian villages—exhaust our cultural and historical stereotypes, even the mass-cultural ones. That they offer some kind of grand narrative, however, does seem to me to be the case, or at least they make the search for one somehow inevitable and unavoidable. But is this inclusion of two Science-Fictional futures enough to justify the characterization of *Cloud Atlas* as a new form of the historical novel defined by its relation to future fully as much as to past?

The great television interviewer Larry King was once asked the kind of question with which he liked to probe his own celebrities, namely what his own attitude—now retired himself and "getting on in years" as people say—what his own attitude was towards death. His memorable answer ran as follows: the worst thing about dying is that I will never find out what comes next. You may feel that this forthright answer blurts out a doubly unacceptable submission to the plot of linear history. Still, it has the merit of reminding us of a historicity we rarely take into account in this age of extraordinarily intricate and paradoxical theories of time and history, and it certainly characterizes the most striking feature of the experience of reading *Cloud Atlas*.[48]

[48] It might be well at this point to take into account Jean-François Lyotard's novel interpretation of the Kantian sublime in temporal terms, as the terror "kindled by the threat of nothing further happening." J-F Lyotard, "The Sublime and The Avant-Garde," in *The Inhuman*, Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1991, 99.

For we do want to find out what can possibly come next, in this series of stories broken off as surely as Sheherezade's; and while the rather disreputable notion of mere garden-variety suspense lies ready to hand, it scarcely suffices to cover the suspense we are also made to feel about history itself in the peculiar structure of this novel. I want to say, with Victor Hugo, that this masks that; and that the philosophical question about future history and indeed about the future history of the planet itself is one which all true historical novels must raise today. That "*grand récit*" is then subtly displaced and substituted by the "language game" of the unfinished narratives and their succession. We do not stop asking the illicit question about the former, modestly resigning ourselves to the latter in its absence; we use the latter to pose the former, which we ask through its material disguise. We do not, after all, ask the question, What happens next? at the end of *Waverley* or *War and Peace*, nor even after *Gone with the Wind* or *Shogun*.[49]

The trick is of course the substitution of one form of curiosity with another: for the anxiety about what happens next in history is substituted our immediate concern about what happens next in the cliffhanger we are reading right now. It is a stepped structure, in which we read the beginnings of the various stories in chronological order, reversing our direction at the apex where we descend the other slope, closing each narrative parenthesis until we reach our beginning again (which is not, of course, our own present.) So a smaller "language-game" answer is provided for each "grand-narrative" question, and instead of the satisfaction of learning our ultimate destiny, we are given that of solving riddles that move further and further into the past, concluding with the sequel and happy ending to Adam Ewing's Pacific Journal of 1849 which opened the text. Has *Cloud Atlas* then succeeded in making the whale-like bulk of History heave into view even briefly like the marine life Adam Ewing views from his railing? The historicity of Mitchell's novel derives from a good deal more than its unique form which we have associated with the most famous and illustrious collection of tales in existence (offering yet another "image of the thought of time" not noted in our previous enumerations), but

[49] But in SF the ending is sometimes achieved by positing a future of this future, as in London's *The Iron Heel* (or the withdrawal of the camera into a far future at the end of *Road Warrior*):

> And they are gone–ay, ages long ago
> These lovers fled away into the storm.

which also takes the linguistic form of embedding, or the intercalation within a simple-sentence syntax of all manner of dependent clauses. The anthropological linguists, indeed, believe that this form is at the origin of properly human thought itself; while its most outlandish embodiment is to be found in that most peculiar of all modernist artifacts, the *Nouvelles Impressions d'Afrique* of Raymond Roussel, a poem in the form of one gigantic sentence within which parentheses begin to open within parentheses until, at the other side of the watershed, they start to close again, much to the reader's relief, whose human mind, it should be added, is structurally incapable of recalling their beginnings after a very limited opening number. (How high can the Unconscious count? was indeed a favorite problem on which Lacan liked to ruminate.)

The truly historical nature of *Cloud Atlas*'s materials lies elsewhere, however, and takes two possibly related forms. The first can be identified as the postmodern practice of pastiche, which offers one answer to our positioning of this work in opposition to those founded on a postmodern play with historical names. The latter was indeed posited as the formal descendent of a high Lukácsian historical realism in which world-historical named individuals constituted a horizon of event and a mid-range of summits in the middle distance. The position we are trying to block out here would then be the alternate one of the novel of the anonymous masses, the movements of the peoples, the historical period itself (whose events are little more than its symptoms). It is a dimension of history we have associated in passing with nostalgia film, and it is time to reveal the deeper kinship of this contemporary version with pastiche, or in other words with historical periods grasped as styles. If the aesthetic of the modern consisted in the effort to invent new styles as so many approaches to the Absolute, the postmodern, ratifying the exhaustion of that project and of the possibilities available to it, now indexes the styles it left behind as so many modes in which periodization is reified and available in a kind of postmodern forgery in the loftiest sense (forgers of great talent working their reincarnations effectively as holograms or androids). To be sure, there remains a necessary and causal relationship between form and content here, where the latter provides the raw material demanded by the style in question in order to be reproduced. Yet style, besides being a historical category in the spirit of the modernist aesthetic (as a historical moment in its own right), is also anthropologically historical in the deeper sense of what constitutes the

superstructure of a mode of production as such, or at least what can be recovered and described of that superstructure.

It is therefore of no little significance that *Cloud Atlas* proceeds by a series of distinct genres and pastiches. Unlike a modernist equivalent, such as the "Oxen of the Sun" chapter of Joyce's *Ulysses*, which purports to follow the evolution of English style from its earliest beginnings, as an analogue of the formation of the embryo in the womb (it takes place in a maternity hospital), the generic sequences of *Cloud Atlas* mime style as the evolution of taste, experience and the social constraints that determine "adventure" in history, beginning with English seamen's limited thoughts on what constitutes civilized, or on the contrary "uncivilized," behavior. This is the sense in which the final Hawaiian episode can perhaps be considered a picture of regression and the collapse of "civilization" as such, the reversion to barbarism. Once again, however, the form plays tricks on us, as it substitutes a different kind of cyclical reversion—the gradual working our way back down through the episodes to the initial Pacific journal—for the larger cyclical "philosophy of history" or grand narrative implied by this particular far future.

But this is only one of the language games, or experiments of time, that *Cloud Atlas* has in store for us. A beginning, a middle, and an ending, but not necessarily in that order, a great filmmaker once said, neglecting to add that they could not only be shuffled and rearranged at will but also superimposed within a single framework. For in *Cloud Atlas*, and from a different perspective, we may say that the endings come in the middle, at the moment of reaching the farthest point "that thought can reach"; and these points are very familiar to us, since they are the farthest points our own thought can reach, namely dystopia and regression, world dictatorship and the reversion to savagery, civilization and barbarism, *1984* and *Road Warrior*, states and nomads, with their respective lines of flight in religion and science, the transmission of salvational legend and the safeguarding of the last great scientific discoveries. *Cloud Atlas* thereby fulfills one of the great indispensable functions of ideological analysis: namely to show the contradictions in which we are ourselves imprisoned, the opposition beyond which we cannot think. These alternatives are today and for the moment the only ways in which we can imagine our future, the future of late capitalism; and it is only by shattering their twin dominion that we might conceivably be able again to think politically and productively, to envisage a condition of genuine revolutionary

difference, to begin once again to think Utopia. Meanwhile, we are here abandoned with our twin absolute limits, take your choice, no other futures conceivable, so that relief has to come in the gradual stepping back down from those twin inevitabilities onto the respective happy endings in reverse order, ending up in the past of our own present, in a nineteenth century that looks more like our eighteenth century, Captain Cook instead of Melville, a past present already resolved and reassuringly over for us and simpler than our own unfinished problems: not the present as history but the future as over and done with.

There is, however, yet another history hidden in these sequences, one perhaps more materialistic than the stylistic variations, even though intimately associated with them; and that is what must be called the medium as such. Each segment, each story, is indeed registered by a different material apparatus of transmission, so that to that extent *Cloud Atlas* offers a kind of experimental history, not so much of styles and events, as rather of communicational technology: indeed the deeper continuity of the work, itself a kind of narrative one, if you like, but an inconspicuously narrative thread at that, lies in the ingenious linkage of each of these segments to the next one, which at one point or another explicitly thematizes it. Thus Adam Ewing's handwritten seaboard journal partially survives into the second segment, where it is read by the composer with some interest (the missing part is then found in the concluding sequence). As for the composer (whose Sextet is actually played in a number of contexts later on), he writes letters, some of which are read by the reporter in the third segment (and the rest of the packet appropriately rediscovered in its concluding sequel). As for the reporter herself, whose adventures we imagine we are reading as a straightforward narrative, the latter is in fact a manuscript submitted to the publisher-protagonist of the fourth segment, whose story we also imagine "*en direct*," until we find that it has been made into a fiction film, viewed in the far future of the next segment. That one is in fact Suonmi's interrogation by her executioners and has been registered on a kind of hologram device, which has been preserved somehow into the still farther future, inasmuch as she has by then been transformed into the central figure of a new religion, to whom the final narrator prays. So the heterogeneity of narratives has been revealed to be a multiplicity of informational and communicational technologies, à la Kittler; and thereby a materialist infrastructure of narrative and historiography restored, much as

in *Krapp's Last Tape* it is the tape player itself who becomes the central figure and interlocutor on an empty stage.[50]

The term "postmodern novel" seems indeed to have become a generic category in recent years; but it is important to distinguish this kind of materiality of the communicational systems from the complacent writing about writing that the term generally designates. The effects here are on the contrary reminiscent of those of the *nouveau roman* rather than of Gide's *Counterfeiters*. In Robbe-Grillet, for example, we find descriptions of a suitably sadistic kind in which a naked young woman is described, bound and gagged by some unknown assailant. As in certain moments of cinema, however, the uncertainty as to whether the shot is "objective" or "subjective," whether in other words we are witnessing the scene through the eyes of another character or merely from the neutral vantage point of the camera, comes into play in a more specifically literary or linguistic mode: the next sentence draws back, as it were, away from what turns out to have been a keyhole, and the hitherto living and writhing victim turns out to be a semi-pornographic photograph on the cover of a magazine. It is a shock effect which on the one hand turns

[50] I have been interested in the adaptation of novels into films for too long to be able to avoid commenting on the ambitious new film version of *Cloud Atlas* (directed by the Wachowskis and Tom Tykwer, 2012). My conclusion (see my Afterword to Colin MacCabe, et al., eds., *True to the Spirit*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011) was that unless both are bad, either the original or the film adaptation must necessarily be superior to its opposite number. If both are equal in value and impact (as for example in the Lem/Tarkovsky *Solaris* texts), then each will necessarily be radically different in spirit from the other. The film version of *Cloud Atlas* would seem to refute these conclusions and in particular to offer an instance in which some equivalence is achieved. Yet here, I think, one has only to recall the great Dickens adaptations of the immediate postwar period, and it will begin to dawn on us that these films (and the excellent *Cloud Atlas* film along with them) are not filmic as much as dramatic adaptations, as it were for the stage, with prodigious feats of character acting, of which one can agree that, yes, the Beadle must have been something like that, the young composer must have been something like this. These performances, then, do not cancel out other versions, as a genuine filmic adaptation always seems to do (Laurence Olivier will always be Heathcliff, no matter what new versions are presented, and without any thought as to what this permanent identification might do to the book). So the film version of Mitchell's novel may not be a great film, even though one cannot say that it is inferior to the book, but it is a magnificent collection of performances. I would also want to add, and this is a more serious critique, that the medium has the unfortunate effect of reifying all the thematic references (the birthmark, for example), thereby unifying its time scheme illicitly into this or that religious or supernatural interpretation, which the novel so subtly evades.

(fictional) reality into an image, and on the other foregrounds the medium itself in what I have called a materialistic fashion.

In *Cloud Atlas* this is something that happens *après coup*, as it were, and retroactively, after we have moved into the next-story segment which reveals the nature of what we have been reading in the last. I am tempted to see this as a serious defamiliarization of the whole ideological thematics of information and communication which has become omnipresent today and a virtually official philosophy of the postmodern. This intrusion of technological consciousness into the reading process at once demotes that official philosophy to a conceptual reflex of the mode of production and in its own way rewrites the history of the alleged "break" of the newer technologies with the older modern ones. It is in any case significant that *Cloud Atlas* overleaps the moment of computers and the Internet in its temporally ambitious chronology, and stages our own present as historical by diminishing it to a passing stage between nostalgia-pasts and a Science-Fictional far future.

I have been promoting the idea that the most valuable works are those that make their points by way of form rather than content, that relativize their themes and ideas, their "meanings," to the benefit of formal demonstrations that do not require interpretation to "produce" their problems (or their problematic, to revive a useful word from yesteryear). Indeed, Lyotard's very notion of the "*grand récit*" aimed in a parallel direction, it seems to me, insofar as the "philosophies of history" he denounced (liberalism and Marxism) all in one way or another involved the transformation of history into ideas and meanings: the one "freedom," the other "emancipation." So it was not so much narrative that he was calling into question as rather the illicit interpretation of narrative by the organization of equally illicit continuities: Hegel is here the fundamental paradigm, even though his notion of the movement of human history towards an ever greater realization of freedom was argued in subtle and complex fashion by way of his conception of the "ruses" of History or Reason—something like an unconscious of history in a quasi-pre-Freudian sense.

But *Cloud Atlas*, alas, does also seem to have a meaning and an interpretation of that kind (and ironically one in which freedom and emancipation are conjoined, as it turns out). For it is a history of imprisonments: the enslavement of the Moriori, the confinement of Ewing to his exiguous cabin, the penniless destitution of the young composer, the surveillance of the atomic energy site, the confinement

of the elderly publisher, the arrest and condemnation of the android, and finally the island itself, on which the more peaceful inhabitants are threatened by a seemingly invincible warlike tribe next door. But in the second part—the descending curve of the stacked narratives—these desperate situations are all somehow resolved, and happy endings provided to what looked like any number of nightmares of History. Do we then have to accept this authorial intention, which has been reinforced by any number of demonstrations of the inherent evil of mankind: "the weak are meat, the strong do eat" (503)? Or is this particular "philosophy of history" simply thrown out, like the repetitive patterns, as a sop to the reader who still needs "meanings"?

Yet this immense glissando through all the styles and affects of history, whose unremitting greed it handles with comic precision, leaves behind it the taste of that immemorial cruelty which is human history itself and which Hegel could only think of as one endless slaughterhouse. The joyousness of this art, captured page by page by the thematics of transmission and the technological media, is scarcely contradicted by our other sense of prolonged horror, itself not cancelled either by the salvational assurance that we have come through! We have escaped the inevitable, inescapable peril, and the doom of history's desperate and repeated emprisonments, and are still alive! The far-future of the scientific survivors, reminding us of Kim Stanley Robinson's insistence on science as the true non-alienated labor as which art was once seen, is radically distinct from this closing quasi-religious devotion of Adam Ewing to his new mission; and yet the two strands, sheerly ideological in the isolation of each, are comparable to distinct orchestral voices heard together, as at one and the same time are the notes of cannibalistic violence and unremitting greed scarcely effaced from this articulate mass of sound by its other dimensions. The aestheticians return again and again to the problem of the extra-artistic and referential dimensions of art, in its shabby ideological messages and its altogether insufficient and rather pitiful calls to this or that action, this or that indignation or "call to arms" (as Lu Xun put it), this or that coming to consciousness. But the moment of the aesthetic is not that call but rather its reminder that all those impulses exist: the revolutionary Utopian one full as much as the immense disgust with human evil, Brecht's "temptation of the good," the will to escape and to be free, the delight in craftsmanship and production, the implacably satiric, unremittingly skeptical gaze. Art has no function but to reawaken all these differences at once in an ephemeral

instant; and the historical novel no function save to resurrect for one more brief moment their multitudinous coexistence in History itself. After that, the reader sinks back into the current situation, which may or may not have some similarity to what has just been glimpsed.

So it is that Lukács' warning about "modernization" in the historical novel, recreating the past in the image of ourselves and omitting its radical difference and the originalities of its cultures and miseries, its class oppressions, turns into something like the injunction of the Red Queen: getting so far ahead of ourselves that only our imaginary futures are adequate to do justice to our present, whose once buried pasts have all vanished into our presentism. "Our philosophies" want to absorb all these foreign totalities as identical with us and flesh of our flesh; Science Fiction wants desperately to affirm them as different and as alien, in its quest for imaginary futures. In an ideal world, perhaps, they would be different and identical all at once at one and the same time: at any rate, for better or for worse, our history, our historical past and our historical novels, must now also include our historical futures as well.

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